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INTRODUCTION

Hello and welcome to Play-by-Play - Sportscast Training. For the first time, there's a play-by-play sportscasting course for you to sink your teeth into. This is a Five-Phase introduction to the exciting world of sports play-by-play and we hope you will enjoy the ride.

Our goal is to make this a wonderful learning experience for you. We want you to learn from us and yourself as you develop your skills through the course.

This is the first time a National Sportscasting Course has been made available to the public. There have been broadcasting courses and schools which have included a little play-by-play, but never a National Course devoted exclusively to this art.

We want to work with you during the next few months to make you aware of your own abilities, to enhance them, to answer questions, clarify concepts of play-by-play, and to give you the foundation for building a career in this highly specialized field.

THE FIVE PHASES INCLUDE:

Phase One- Basic Introduction to Play-by-Play Sportscasting.

Phase Two- A Comprehensive Presentation and Development of Basic Play-by-Play Sportscasting.

Phase Three- An Introduction and Presentation of Interviewing Technique and Preparing a Sports Show.

Phase Four- Discussion of Advanced Play-by-Play Technique and Delivery.

Phase Five- Final Assignment- Putting It Altogether.

We will provide you with BOTH oral and written critiques. The oral critiques will be on the audio tapes you submit as part of each phase assignment. The written critique will support the oral critique and give you something to look at while listening to the oral critique.

You submit only ONE assignment at a time. Do not send in other assignments until the previous one has been critiqued and returned to you. This will allow you to listen and learn before moving on to another phase.

-CRITIQUES-

The critiques are the backbone of your progress. They will be objective, to the point and will be encouraging. They will tell you the areas where you are doing well or where you need to improve.

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The critiques will tell you HOW TO IMPROVE, what you need to do to move your performance level even higher.

It makes no difference whether you are a beginner in the world of sportscasting or already a professional. The biggest problem anyone has in sportscasting is having someone who can objectively critique their work.

THIS COURSE WILL PROVIDE THOSE CRITIQUES FOR YOU.

Your instructor's backgrounds are documented for you, but a few words here will be appropriate. Between them, Al Epstein and Lou Riggs have some 40 years of professional broadcasting experience doing play-by-play. They not only do play-by-play, they have taught broadcasting for many years.

So, listen carefully to your critiques and you will learn tremendously, in the space of a few months, what many sportscasters have never learned--how to prepare, how to deliver, how to do a play-by-play radio broadcast.

Most sportscasters get very little "hands-on" experience before they get their first job. They might have used their tape recorders in the stands of a little league game or a major league baseball game. They might have had a class or two in a broadcasting school or college. But, they were almost never really given the foundation they needed when they got that first job.

Play-By-Play - Sportscast training will give you that foundation. The rest, of course, is up to you.

-Radio Play-By-Play-

Now, the emphasis here is on RADIO play-by-play. The reason is simple. You're at home, or in your office, or practicing in the cellar, wherever. We don't have television monitors to work with, so our concentration is on radio.

A word of advice. The best play-by-play broadcasters, whether radio or television, got their basic knowledge from doing radio. You can always tone down your presentation for television. Radio teaches you how to paint a word picture, to describe action, events, orchestrate the ball game for the listening audience. It's a wonderful feeling to call an exciting game and know you prepared, did your homework, and delivered the product in a professional manner.

The "high" you get from actually calling the play-by-play of a game is incredible. It's exhilirating, ego gratifying and will keep you up hours after the game is over just thinking about it. There's nothing quite like it in broadcasting.

You will need THREE types of equipment for your "radio" broadcasts: 1- A tape recorder, 2- A microphone, 3- Audio Tapes.

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As you go into each phase, you will be given very specific instruction as to what the assignment will be, advice about equipment to have, a "survival kit," how to phrase, how to prepare spotting boards, what they look like, how to use them.

This course is for anyone interested in sportscasting and play-by-play. Age makes no difference, nor does current occupation, educational background, whether male or female, tall or short, heavy or lean. Sportscasters come in all sizes and shapes and backgrounds.

The important element is your desire to learn what play-by-play sportscast training is all about. You may find this is what you want to do the rest of your life. You may find that it would be fun to do some of the time, or even as a hobby.

There are jobs all over the country, especially the medium to smaller markets. Good play-by-play sportscasters are hard to find. This will give you a real "leg up" on other would-be sportscasters.

Study, listen, work hard, learn and give it your best.

Again, welcome to Play-by-Play - Sportscast Training.

Sincerely,
Lou Riggs and Al Epstein

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PLAY-BY-PLAY - SPORTSCAST TRAINING
THE AUTHORS

Al Epstein

Al Epstein, a veteran play-by-play sportscaster for 15 years, has always been involved in sports- - -working as a sports information director in junior college, a head coach in basketball at the prep level, as well as playing high school and college baseball.

Epstein, a former Associated Press West Coast Award PBP winner, has broadcast numerous college sporting events, including Nevada - Las Vegas football, Pepperdine University basketball, and UCLA baseball.

Born and raised in Los Angeles, Epstein has also announced high school football, basketball, and baseball throughout Southern California.

Epstein graduated from California State Los Angeles with a Bachelor of Arts Degree in Broadcast Journalism. He has been an instructor in sportscasting and announcing for over eight years, also teaching at the Sportscaster Camps of America since 1987.

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PLAY-BY-PLAY - SPORTSCAST TRAINING
THE AUTHORS

Lou Riggs

Lou Riggs has broadcast sports play-by-play in Southern California since 1970, including college football, basketball, baseball, pro volleyball, soccer and softball.

He also hosted sports and entertainment shows during the same time, was Sports Director for KCRW radio for 15 years; sports editor of the L.A. Times Audio-Tex News.

Born in Los Angeles, Riggs received his AA degree in Journalism/Broadcasting at Santa Monica College, his BA in Journalism from Cal State Los Angeles. He taught in The Radio-TV-Film Dept. at Cal State Northridge for five years, has been an Associate Professor at Santa Monica College since 1984, teaching sports broadcasting and communications. He has been a national instructor for Columbia School of Broadcasting since 1985.

Riggs is a broadcast coach for Fox Sports Net, has been broadcasting UCLA sports since 1992 (men's/women's volleyball, women's basketball and softball). He co-anchored radio and television broadcasts for Santa Anita Race Track, 1985-92.

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PLAY-BY-PLAY SPORTSCAST TRAINING

PHASE ONE

BASIC INTRODUCTION TO PLAY-BY-PLAY

AUTHORED BY

AL EPSTEIN

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PLAY-BY-PLAY - SPORTSCAST TRAINING
PHASE 1 - BY AL EPSTEIN

BASIC INTRODUCTION TO PLAY-BY-PLAY

WHAT IS PLAY-BY-PLAY ?

I guess the first thought that comes to mind is, what is play-by-play? At PLAY-BY-PLAY - SPORTSCAST TRAINING (PBP-ST), we have defined this as the ability to call a sporting event with a concise description of the action, while maintaining a natural delivery.

Your energy, feeling, involvement, pacing, articulation, and experience are all aspects of defining play-by-play. And perhaps, most of all, **preparation**, **preparation**, and **preparation**. How you prepare; what you prepare; and the time you prepare for the sporting event, are all realized in your development as a sportscaster.

There is no magical answer - - - no easy way. Play-by-play is a learned art, very much like studying to become an actor, musician, singer, or comedian. This takes practice and commitment, desire and time to develop as a sportscaster.

OUR GOALS FOR THE SPORTSCASTER.

Our goal is to help develop your skills as a play-by-play announcer. We'll teach you the basic fundamentals of play-by-play, whether you are just beginnng, or currently broadcasting high school, college, and/or pro sports.

We will teach you the fundamentals of play calling; how and what to prepare for a broadcast and how to develop your interview technique and sports reporting delivery. We will do this through our written instruction manual and constructive critiquing of your sportscasts with our "on air" professional sportscasters. We will also give you assignments that will allow you to develop your play-by-play, interview, and sports reporting skills.

Although we are also sending you the entire FIVE PHASE manual, we have designed the training as a step-by-step program. We recommend that you take each phase in order so there is continuity in your training and progress.

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You are also receiving self-evaluation sheets to critique yourself. **For the course you will need a tape recorder, a separate microphone, and audio cassette tapes.**

OBJECTIVITY IN SPORTSCASTING.

Ideally, you should love sports, read the sports pages, have some knowledge of basic rules and understand the terminology. However, you don't have to be an "expert" to become a sportscaster.

With study, inquisitiveness and preparation you can learn all you need to know about a sport. With that preparation, you can put together a successful broadcast, whether it's a football, basketball, or baseball game. The same study and effort can also prepare you to do other sports and interviews.

Whether you are a beginning sports broadcaster or one with experience, the keys are **preparation** and **effort**.

The first thing you must realize, as a sportscaster, is that you are no longer a fan sitting and cheering for your team. You are now the eyes and ears, the voice to the radio listening audience. Your role is to be an objective, knowledgeable, enthusiastic, and informative announcer. Being objective is important. First of all, you are a professional. If you're rooting for a team openly, you lose your believability and credibility. How can a listener believe what you're saying when everything is "slanted" toward "your" team. When on the air, maintain your objectivity and professionalism at all times. The audience will hear your "cheerleading" in a very short time.

LISTENING TO LOCAL OR NATIONAL PBP ANNOUNCERS.

The next step is listen to local and national radio and TV play-by-play announcers. Listen to the words and/or phrasing they use to describe the action. Study their phraseology and terminology. Write them on paper and study them for reference. Most descriptions of each play are basically the same, but there are different ways to call any given play:

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PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - FOOTBALL - PHRASING "TO PASS"

1. "Jones back to pass."
2. "Jones will throw."
3. "Jones will take to the air."
4. "Jones fires."

ILL. # 1

Keep a book of phrases and break down each part of the game, whether it is football, basketball, baseball, or any other sport. The key phrases will help your style of delivery, and you should develop different ways of calling the same play to avoid repetition. Be creative.

PLAY-BY-PLAY - SPORTSCAST TRAINING deals mainly with football, basketball, and baseball because these three sports are the most commonly broadcast. However, the same theories apply to hockey, soccer, tennis, and other sports.

WHAT TO "BREAK DOWN."

Here are just a few things to listen for in developing your phrasing/wording in a sportscast.

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - FOOTBALL - "HOW TO CALL"

1. A touchdown run.
2. A touchdown pass.
3. A long complete or incomplete pass.
4. A short complete or incomplete pass.
5. A receiver making a catch.
6. The quarterback "handing -off" to a running back.
7. A run, sweep, or reverse.
8. Setting the offense and defense.
9. Giving the score and time; how often.
10. The kick-off; a punt.

ILL. # 2

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PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - BASKETBALL - "HOW TO CALL"

1. Giving the score and time.
2. Setting the line-ups.
3. A personal and team foul.
4. Different shots - jumper, 3-point shot, hook shot, dunk, lay-up.
5. Describing each part of the court - the lane, right and left side, baseline, backcourt, top of the key.
6. Setting the offense and defense.
7. Bringing a substitution, another player into the game.
8. Information about a player, other than just his name.
9. Individual scoring.
10. Recapping statistics for individuals and teams.

ILL. # 3

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - BASEBALL - "HOW TO CALL"

1. Setting the defense and starting line-ups.
2. Pre and post game shows.
3. A commercial break (outcue) - setting the stage after commercial.
4. A pitcher's delivery and type of pitch.
5. A base hit, double, triple, and home run.
6. A ground out; a fly out.
7. Movement of runners; a stolen base.
8. Description of the field; each area and position.
9. Wrap-up of an inning.
10. How and what information to use as "filler."

ILL. # 4

Keep in mind these are only basic and fundamental actions to describe. Add your own to these lists. As you work a game develop your own descriptions and phrases. Write these down for future reference.

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Remember, you are only calling the action that is occuring on the field. Do not use unnecessary wording, **just be direct and concise**.

Practice these phrases by making up game situations, calling the action on TV, or by going to a game. It takes practice to recognize each play and to apply the proper wording to describe it.

This is not difficult, but it does take practice and experience. After all, you are only calling what is taking place on the court or field; just calling what you see. Don't worry about making mistakes. We've all heard play-by-play announcers make mistakes- - -even after twenty years of being on the air. This happens to all of us. **However, it's how you handle these mistakes that is important**. We will discuss this and show you how to handle these situations in Phase Four.

STYLES - PLAY-BY-PLAY ANNOUNCERS.

Everyone has a unique delivery, style, energy level, and personality in calling a sporting event. **The most important part of your delivery is to be natural- - -be yourself**.

Don't try to "announce" (this is called being "announcy") or be unnatural. Do not try to be someone you're not. It takes practice and time to develop your delivery and style- - -naturally. Your personality, energy, feeling, delivery of information, pacing, articulation, and calling the action, all have to be natural. This is the real key to becoming a good play-by-play sportscaster.

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There are all kinds of PBP styles:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - STYLES - PLAY-BY-PLAY

1. "The Homer" - always "rooting" for his/her team on the air. (Not recommended).
2. "The Screamer" - someone who is totally out of control and difficult to understand. (Not Recommended)
3. "The Comedian" - someone who forces humor that is unnecessary. (Not Recommended)
4. "The Slow, Deliberate Paced Announcer" - this sounds unnatural, and mechanical. Announcer is trying to be too careful. (Loosen up)
5. "The Fast Paced Announcer" - very common. Too rushed and difficult to follow. (Relax)
6. "The High Energy, Intense Announcer" - when the score is 2-0, the intensity is unnecessary. (Makes every play the "*End of The World*")
7. "The Low Energy Announcer" - You need energy and enthusiasm in a natural delivery. (Ho hum, wake me when it's over)

ILL. # 5

The good announcers are natural, intelligent, well prepared, energetic, articulate, and experienced and they are working with **controlled** energy and enthusiasm. This should be your goal. Above all, these announcers have the knowledge of basic fundamental play-by-play calling and the experience to apply their knowledge.

FUNDAMENTALS OF PLAY-BY-PLAY.

There are five (5) basic fundamentals to play-by-play we feel that are important:

1-SCORE

2-TIME

3-WHO HAS THE BALL

4-WHERE THE BALL IS

5-PACING

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These fundamentals can improve your play calling tremendously, even if you have never broadcast a game. It helps to have a basic understanding of sports, the rules, knowledge of the game, teams and players, but if you follow the fundamentals you're off to a great start.

SCORE AND TIME.

The FIRST TWO fundamentals that you need to remember are the SCORE and TIME. Although this sounds simple, you can never give the score and time enough. Even the most experienced announcers fail to do this. This should be your main focus. Remember, listeners "tune in and out." They always want to know the TIME and SCORE .

You usually give the team with the lead first (LA 25 - Boston 19). Do not say, "Boston 19 - LA 25." But, it is alright to say, "Boston trailing LA, 25-19."

You need to develop several ways of delivering the score and time. Time also includes period, quarter, half, or inning.

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - "TIME AND SCORE"

1. "6:19 left in the first quarter, LA leads Boston, 25-19."
2. "LA 25 - Boston 19, 6:19 to go, first quarter."
3. "LA out in front of Boston, 25-19. 6:19 remaining in the first period."

ILL. # 6

In basketball, especially, you need to **give the score after every point**. However, it is not necessary to give the time after every score. Never let any great amount of time (maybe one (1) or two (2) minutes) elapse without giving the time and score. Remember, you can never give the score and time too often.

Other sports (baseball, football, hockey, etc.), where there isn't as much scoring, always have an awareness of the time, and give the score often.

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WHO AND WHERE.

Fundamentals three and four are, (3) WHO HAS THE BALL, and (4) WHERE THE BALL IS on the court/field. Once again, this sounds simple, but you need to train yourself in describing where the ball is and who has it (this can also include what he/she is doing with the ball- - -passing, running, dribbling, shooting, etc.).

In order to describe where the ball is on the court/field, you need to familiarize yourself with each area of the playing surface. This means going to a basketball court, football/baseball field, or looking at a diagram, and writing down phrases that describe areas of the court/field.

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - WHAT TO DESCRIBE - BASKETBALL COURT

1. The key - (right and left side).
2. The baseline - (right and left side).
3. Top of the key.
4. Frontcourt, backcourt, and sideline.
5. Right and left wing.
6. Three-point range.
7. In the lane.
8. At the free throw line.
9. Distance of shot.
10. Out of bounds.

ILL. # 7

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - FOOTBALL FIELD

1. The sidelines, over the middle.
2. Where the ball is on the field - right or left hash mark.
3. The yard line.
4. The end zone.
5. The goal line.
6. Near side - far side.
7. Left-to-right.
8. Right-to-left.

ILL. # 8

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PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - BASEBALL FIELD

1. The infield and outfield.
2. Right and left field "foul" lines.
3. Short or deep hit.
4. Up the middle.
5. Between first and second base, third base and shortstop.
6. Power alleys.
7. Warning track.

ILL. # 9

These are just a few examples, but you need to develop your own. Identify and know instantly when the ball or player are in a certain area. Describing where the ball is allows the listener to visualize the game action even more.

Who has the ball, not only refers to an INDIVIDUAL, but to the TEAM in possession as well.

When there is a change of possession, such as in basketball, you need to know how to describe it. For example:

1. A missed shot and the other team rebounds.
2. A loose ball and the other team recovers.
3. An offensive foul and the other team takes possession.
4. A "held ball" (5-second violation) and the other team takes over.

YOU ALWAYS NEED TO RE-ESTABLISH THE TEAM WHO HAS THE BALL.

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - BASKETBALL - CHANGE OF POSSESSION

1. "25-21, LA leads; Jones shoots and misses, Smith grabs the rebound for Boston, Smith front court."
2. (LA) "Jones throws the ball away, Smith has it for Boston."
3. (LA) "Jones charges into Smith on the drive and Boston takes over on the offensive foul."

ILL. # 10

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As a play-by-play announcer you need to inform the listener of:

1. Who has the ball.
2. Where he/she is.
3. What he/she is doing.

You need to describe this in the fewest words possible. "Word economy" is the phrase to keep in mind.

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - DESCRIBING THE ACTION - BASKETBALL

1. "Jones, right side, dribbling."

ILL. # 11

In four words we have given:

1. Who has the ball (Jones).
2. Where the ball is (right side).
3. What Jones is doing (dribbling).

The common mistake is to be too wordy.

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - DESCRIBING THE ACTION - TOO MANY WORDS

1. "Jones with the ball now, on the right side of the key, and dribbling the ball."
2. "Jones grabs the rebound and throws a long pass to Johnston who drives the lane and lays it in."

ILL. # 12

The first example is sixteen (16) words. Remember to be direct and concise. In basketball, if the pace of the game is too fast, you need to use the fewest words possible to describe the action.

Remember to concentrate on **who** has the ball and **where** he/she is on the playing surface.

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PACING.

The FIFTH fundamental in play-by-play is PACING. This is probably the most difficult to learn in play calling- - -going too fast or too slow.

Remember, a natural pace and flow of the game, delivered with an easy-to-understand description of the action is your objective.

When the play-by-play announcer, especially basketball, is too fast, the announcer is using too many words and trying to include every pass, dribble, and movement. This is not necessary and can "lose" the listener in a hurry. SLOW DOWN.

The common tendency in basketball, **when trying to call everything**, is that you will find yourself behind the play (a shot and/or a score), then rushing to catch-up.

If you fall behind the play, still maintain your natural pacing and realize you can recap the action. **Don't rush to catch-up**.

It is alright to miss a pass, a dribble, or bringing the ball up the floor. This is a good time to recap the previous play, give the time and score, or bring other information into the broadcast.

Keep in mind, you do not want to miss a shot, a score, a foul, or rebound- - -**these are the important aspects of the game**.

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION -BASKETBALL - RECAPPING THE PREVIOUS PLAY

1. (Player just dribbling). "Jones, right side. Smith, at the other end had a great move for his 10th point, and gives LA the lead, 25-19."

BASKETBALL - BRINGING INFORMATION INTO THE BROADCAST

2. (Player just dribbling). "Jones, top of the key... 25-19, LA leads...6:19 left in the first quarter. Jones last season scored a career high 25 points against LA." (The action continues). "Smith, baseline jumper from 10 feet is good."

ILL. # 13

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Football and baseball are ideal sports for a natural pace. However, the action can pick up quickly and you must be careful not to rush your delivery on a long pass/run, or a driving hit. You could be talking about the weather, then all of a sudden- - -a big play, a lot of action.

If you rush, your play-by-play will sound uneven and unnatural to the listener. The fast pace also tends to cause mistakes, slurring and mispronunciation of words.

A medium, natural pace works best. Be careful of being too deliberate, mechanical, or unnatural in your delivery. An easy, natural delivery comes with experience and self confidence.

THE SPORTSBOARD - PREPARATION.

Your SPORTSBOARD is probably the most important source of information for the broadcast. This is the culmination of your research and preparation; gathering information on the players and teams, their backgrounds and statistics.

Your board should be easily read and accessible for you. Memorize the line-ups from the boards, using names, never numbers, to describe the players for a radio broadcast. Television is where it would be appropriate to use a number in helping the audience to know who you are talking about.

We have provided examples of some sportsboards. Develop your own board that is comfortable for you.

Basically, this is what you need to include on your sportsboard:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - SPORTSBOARD - BASIC INFORMATION

1. Positions.
2. Players' uniform numbers.
3. Names of players.
4. Height, weight, year, and hometown/high school/college.
5. Statistics - players/teams.
6. Background information - players/teams, records/averages.
7. Highlight outstanding performances/big scoring games/interesting stories.

ILL. # 14

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Include background information, statistics, and outstanding performances in the broadcast. Statistics, whether individual or team, can be a great source of information. They can show tendencies, strengths or weaknesses, scoring offense and defense, averages and percentages.

Read press releases, newspapers, and talk to coaches for additional information. Start a file for teams you will be covering.

THE SPORTSBOARD - DIFFERENT COLORS.

When "setting up" your board, sometimes you need information quickly. Use different colors for instant identification.

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - SPORTSBOARD - USE OF COLORS

1. Names of players and basic information - black or dark colors.
2. Players numbers - red or green/lighter colors.
3. Statistics - blue/purple.
4. Or, whatever combination works for you.

ILL. # 15

Do not use one color for your sportsboard. This makes it difficult to identify information quickly.

HOW MUCH TIME FOR YOUR SPORTSBOARD?*

How much time should you spend developing your sportsboard? This varies with each individual. You can never prepare enough, even though you may only use half of the information during the game. We recommend a minimum of 4-5 hours and probably more for each game, especially football. Developing a sportsboard helps you familiarize and retain information for the broadcast.

* Sample sportsboards next three pages.

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POS.	NO.	NAME	HT.	WT.	YR.	HOMETOWN
F-	10					
F-	14					
C-	26					
G-	30					
G-	44					
F-	12					
F-	18					
G-	45					
C-	8					
G-	11					
G-	21					
G-	32					

TEAM: _____ **OFFENSE** **COACH** _____

SE/WR **T** **G** **C** **G** **T** **TE**

KICKOFF RETURNS

QB **FL-WB-WR**

RB-FB

HOLDER _____

PUNTERS

RB-TB

PAT/FG/KK

KEY

C=CENTER
G=GUARD
T=TACKLE
TE=TIGHT END
SE=SPLIT END

WR=WIDE RECEIVER
RB-FB=RUNNING/FLANKER BACK
FL-WB=FLANKER/WINGBACK
RB-TB=RUNNING/TAILBACK
PAT=POINT AFTER TOUCHDOWN

QB=QUARTER BACK
FG=FIELD GOAL
KK=KICKOFF

School:_____ **DEFENSE** **COACH:**_____

OLB **DT** **NG** **DT** **OLB**

ILB **ILB**

KICKOFFS

LCB **RCB**

PUNT RETURNS

SS **FS**

KEY

NG=NOSE GUARD
DT=DEFENSIVE TACKLE
OLB=OUTSIDE LINEBACKER
ILB=INSIDE LINEBACKER

LCB=LEFT CORNERBACK
RCB=RIGHT CORNERBACK
SS=STRONG SAFETY
FS=FREE SAFETY

When finally sitting "mikeside" at a game, you should at the very least have a sportsboard, complete numerical rosters, and overall statistics for each team.

SETTING THE STAGE - "IN AND OUT" OF COMMERCIAL BREAKS.

Each time there is a "break in the action" or a time-out, you need to set the score and time, and then deliver your "outcue." There are a number of ways to do this:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - "OUTCUES"

1. "LA 25 Boston 23, 4:20 left in the first quarter. We'll be right back with more; you're listening to Boston basketball on KBBB."
2. "There is a time-out, Boston 76 LA 72, 6:18 left in the third quarter; we'll be right back after these messages."
3. "Boston calls time-out, LA leads 26-20, 2:19 left in the first period; we'll be right back."

ILL. # 16

There are others, and your program director or producer will inform you what outcues the station wants.

When you return from a commercial, again, reset the stage of the game, varying your "scene-sets" each time.

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - RETURN - "SCENE-SET"

1. "Welcome back to the BBB arena; LA trails Boston, 76-72, 6:18 remaining in the third quarter; Boston ball at midcourt."
2. "LA leads Boston, 25-19, 5:01 left in the first period; LA ball in the backcourt, Jones will inbound."

ILL. # 17

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It is important to develop different phrases for setting the stage when "breaking" and returning from commercials. Write them down for your files and memorize.

PRONUNCIATION AND ARTICULATION.

Very important is the pronunciation of unusual names on rosters. Names vary greatly and you should check pronunciation before each game with players, coaches, or sports information personnel. Sometimes the name is so difficult you need to write it down phonetically.

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - PRONUNCIATION - PHONETICALLY

1. John Arilicka - John Are-ee--leek-ah.
2. James Beauchamp - James Beech-um

ILL. # 18

Articulation and enunciation are also important. During a sportscast, you will probably be talking for 3-4 hours. Always be aware of your enunciation. If you are having a problem with certain words or syllables, write them down and practice them. Following are a number of common mistakes involving words, syllables, and consonants (t's, d's, p's as examples).

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - PRONUNCIATION - COMMON MISTAKES

1. -ing words - going/goin - hitting/hittin - throwing/throwin - shooting/shootin
2. t-d words - fast/fas - world/worl - passed/pass
3. vowels (a, e, i, o, u) - accents, short and long vowels - five/fahv - style/stahl

ILL. # 19

Proper pacing will help your diction. If you are rushed, the tendency is to slur words. If this is a problem, practice talking slowly and exaggerate your mouth movement, until your diction improves and is clearly understood.

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GENERAL PLAY-BY-PLAY EXAMPLES.

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - BASKETBALL PHRASING

1. "Jones, jumper top of the key, no good, rebound Smith for Boston...."
2. "Jones rightside, pass inside to Smith, his 5-foot shot is good."
3. "Jones rebounds for Boston, the outlet pass to Smith at midcourt...."

ILL. # 20

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - FOOTBALL PHRASING

1. "1st and 10 at the Boston 25-yard line, Jones at quarterback; Jones gives to Smith off right tackle, and Smith gains 2 yards.
2. "Jones back to pass, fires towards the far sidelines, and it's complete to Smith at the Boston 37-yard line."
3. "Jones pitches to Smith, sweeping the left side, turns the corner at the 25, and is finally tackled at the 30. First and 10 LA."

ILL. # 21

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - BASEBALL PHRASING

1. "Jones with the 1-1 pitch- - -fastball, strike one."
2. "Smith drives it to deep left field, back goes Jones to the fence, and makes the catch- - -for out number one."
3. "Jones swings, ground ball to short, Smith gloves and throws to Carl at first- - -one out."

ILL. # 22

HIGHLIGHTS OF PHASE ONE.

1. The five fundamentals of play-by-play.
2. Your sportsboard - preparation, preparation, **and** preparation.
3. Professionalism and objectivity.
4. Phrasing - listen to your local or national play-by-play announcers.
5. Setting the stage - "in and out" of commercials.

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YOUR GOAL FOR PHASE ONE.

Your goal is to develop, through experience, a natural style and delivery, applying the proper phrasing, while incorporating the five fundamentals of play-by-play:

1-SCORE

2-TIME

3-WHO HAS THE BALL

4-WHERE THE BALL IS

5-PACING

LESSON FOR PHASE ONE.

For Phase One, your assignment is to broadcast a game in person or from a TV set. Listen to the tape, and find the best CONSECUTIVE THREE OR FOUR MINUTES of unedited play-by-play for you and your instructor to critique. Do not concern yourself with mistakes. Handling these mistakes is part of the learning process.

You will need a tape recorder, a separate microphone, and audio cassette and batteries, if an A/C outlet is not available to you.

Practice, work hard, and have fun!

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PLAY-BY-PLAY SPORTSCAST TRAINING

PHASE TWO

A COMPREHENSIVE PRESENTATION AND DEVELOPMENT OF PLAY-BY-PLAY SPORTSCASTING

AUTHORED BY

LOU RIGGS

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PLAY-BY-PLAY - SPORTSCAST TRAINING
PHASE 2 - BY LOU RIGGS

A COMPREHENSIVE PRESENTATION AND DEVELOPMENT OF BASIC PLAY-BY-PLAY SPORTSCASTING

Congratulations. You have completed Phase One of your budding sportscasting career and are now ready for bigger challenges. You probably found that doing radio play-by-play was not as easy as you thought it was going to be.

If that was your reaction to trying to describe that first pitch, the jump shot from the right side, the swing pass into the left flat, center icing, or whatever sport you chose---welcome to the club. Most people find that play-by-play is far more difficult than they ever imagined it could be.

Most "wannabes" (slang for "want to be broadcaster") do not realize how much preparation there is to calling a game---even into a tape recorder. In Phase One, Al Epstein gave you more information than almost anybody has ever had before they attempted their first play-by-play.

Now, we will develop your technique a little more, give you more clues about where to find background information, how to prepare in even more detail, how to use press guides, press releases, newspapers, and how to build a "file" for your games.

We will also discuss the role of the "color commentator" in the broadcast. This will be developed even further as we go into Phase Four.

First, let's discuss use of the SPORTSBOARDS. They will vary with the individual and by sport.

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FOOTBALL SPORTSBOARD.

As you have seen by the example we have included in Phase One (and this will be developed more extensively in Phase Two), there is room for much information. The COLOR CODING should help you here. For example, I use Dark Red, Purple, Blue or Black ink for the player numbers (I.E. #45, #62, #18) if they are starters. I use a different color if they are reserves. I also use different color combinations for starters than I do for reserves.

Football sportsboards can list as few as one or two players for each position at the high school or community college level. The pros would usually be two to three deep because of the limited size of their rosters.

The idea is to list the **starters** in **one color** combination, (red and black, blue and green, etc.), the reserves in a different color scheme. Try to include the people who figure to play at least some portion of the game. Try to list them in the order they might appear so you don't have to search for them in your depth charts.

For example:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - DEPTH CHART - SPORTSBOARD

If #18, John Smith, is the starting SE (Split End) for the Denver Ducks, go ahead and list him at the top of your chart at that position. If his primary backup is #32 Bill Jones, list him second. If #24 Lewis Johnson is a possibility to play at that position, list him third on the depth chart.

Split End

#18 John Smith

6-2, 180, Jr., Los Angeles

#32 Bill Jones

6-1, 175, Sr., San Diego

24 Lewis Johnson

5-10, 150, Soph., Los Angeles

ILL. # 1

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Football also presents other matters to consider, such as the "specialty" players. For example, the regular "center" may not be the one who snaps the ball on extra points, field goal attempts or punts.

You will need to list them separately behind the starting center and specify them by "PAT/FG Snapper" or "Punt Snapper."

By doing this, you avoid the embarrassing situation or saying that (#50) Ray Jones snapped the ball over the punter's head, when it was really punt snapper (#57) Charlie Anthony. Relatively minor mistakes can make for very embarrassing moments for the sportscaster---in addition to ruining one's credibility.

The Sportsboard for football leaves room for statistics which can be listed next to, or below, the player's name.

For example:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - INFORMATION - SPORTSBOARD

16 QB
Rod Martin
6-2, 165, Sr., Notre Dame (college)
2nd year pro
116/234 (represents passes completed, 116, and passes attempted, 234)
49.6% (pass completion percentage)
16 TD's (16 touchdowns)
13 Int. (13 interceptions)
LG 67 TD (represents long gain of 67 yards for a touchdown)

ILL. # 2

All of this information would be listed above or next to the quarterback slot on the sportsboard. **See Sportsboard example at end of Phase Two.**

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The same principle would apply throughout the rest of the board. By using various color codes (stats in red, for example, jersey numbers in blue, names in green) you can know immediately what you are looking for and pick it up easily with a quick scan of the sportsboard.

Basic information including team name, nickname (Wildcats, Zebras, Bears, etc.), record (5-4), league standings (2nd in West), coach's name, record (3rd year, 14-19), type of offense: "run/shoot," "multiple," "pro set," "Wing-T," can also be incorporated into your sportsboard.

This is the key to your entire broadcast. It contains the basic information you will need to have literally at your fingertips.

I strongly recommend that you tape your sportsboards to a strong **cardboard type of backing**. I usually put the offenses of both teams on flip sides of the same cardboard backing. The same for the defense.

Now, why would it make any difference, you might ask? Plenty.

That way, you can never have BOTH OFFENSIVE OR BOTH DEFENSIVE UNITS turned up at the same time. You must remember to flip your boards over (in football) **to represent the unit you see on the field at that time**. If the Denver Ducks are on offense, you will have the Denver Duck OFFENSIVE BOARD up where you can see it. If the Los Angeles Rangoon's Defense is on the field, you want the DEFENSIVE BOARD turned up where you can see it.

Then, you can set the stage by referring to the Offensive Board and you can do the same for the Defensive Board.

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For example:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - USE OF SPORTSBOARD - OFFENSE

1. "Denver at its 45-yard line, Rod Mountain (16) calls out the signals, John Smith (18) wide left, Jones in motion to the far side, the backs are split."

ILL. # 3

You have the offensive board to refer to while setting the offensive formation. Then, when the play unfolds, you can quickly scan your Defensive Board to find where linebacker (#52) Bill Abercrombie plays if he made the tackle.

For example:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - USE OF SPORTSBOARD - DEFENSE

1. "Abercrombie, from his middle linebacking position, closed quickly to make the tackle on Jones as he cut over left tackle. Gain of two yards on the play for Denver, 2nd down and 8 at the Denver 47, 3:52 to go in the third quarter, Denver leading L.A., 17-14."

ILL. # 4

If your sportsboards are incomplete, missing critical information, or are poorly prepared, you will have a very difficult time putting together a quality broadcast.

As Al Epstein mentioned in Phase One, **we strongly urge color coding or combinations.** This will give you a COLOR KEY to work with and also give your eyes a break.

Probably no two sportscasters use exactly the same type of SPORTSBOARD system. You eventually work out what is good for you. All we are doing is giving you suggestions of what we have done, or do, in our own preparation.

Take your time in preparing your SPORTSBOARD. It helps you evaluate the material you have collected, allows you to analyze it, then put it together into a working information base that will enhance your broadcast.

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BASKETBALL SPORTSBOARD.

Basketball is not nearly as complicated, obviously as football. You have far fewer players, they are right in front of you and coaches usually use about 8 to 9 players in a game---unless, of course, it's a rout.

I use a very simple format which is easily prepared. Just take a blank sheet of paper, draw 12 to 14 horizontal lines (representing a line for each player) and fill in by number, name, position, school, year in school (or pros), then fill in the basic scoring information you need.

For example:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - BASKETBALL SPORTSBOARD

1. 10 JOHNNY CARNACK, F, 6-7, 185, Sr., 18.9, 6.7R, 4.0A, 26HG, FG 47%, FT 84.4%.

ILL. # 5

I put these starters in numerical order among the starting five. Then, I include the next three or four key players, by numerical order, as they might appear in the game.

Following those key players, add the reserves, again by numerical order, Again, each sportscaster will develop a system that works for his/her own delivery.

Now, let's back up to "10 John Carnack." The information that followed his name would represent:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - ANALYSIS OF BASKETBALL INFORMATION

1. F (forward), 6-7 (height), 185 (weight), Sr. (senior), 18.9 (scoring average), 6.7R (rebound average), 4.0A (assist average), 26HG (26 points his high game), FG 47% (field goal percentage), FT 84.4% (free throw percentage).

ILL. # 6

See sportsboard example at end of Phase Two.

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All of that is indicated on the line for "John Carnack." Other information might be included: All-tournament at the Valencia Holiday Festival, returning 2nd team All-LA City averaged 14.6 points per game last year, surfing is his hobby, etc.

If you run out of space on the line for the player, go to a **4x6 index card** for additional information. That could include how many 20-point games, his lowest game of the year, game winning baskets, who is recruiting him, where he was born, (brothers/sisters who might have played at the school), occupations of his parents, whether they were athletes or not, biggest moment in sports, academic major, etc.

Again, you need to find out what works best for you in setting up your sportsboards. Experiment, try different things to get the best "working" sportsboard for you.

BASEBALL SPORTSBOARD.

Your sportsboard here will probably be your SCOREBOOK. This will allow you to have the starting lineups, defensive positions, places for Batting Average, Earned Run Average, Home Runs, Runs Batted In, etc., in front of you.

The scorebook should be set up in such a way as to show distance down the foul lines (330 feet, or 330', or 330), power alleys (right and left center, 375' for example) and dead centerfield (410' for example). The height of the outfield wall should be shown, especially if it varies (for example, Boston's Fenway Park).

Also include which is the "sunfield," (generally right field), distance to the grandstand, backstop, bullpens, and dugout. This will give you a feel of distances as you describe pitches, hits, outs and foul balls during the course of your broadcast.

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In addition to your SCOREBOOK for baseball, you should have an INDEX CARD (4x6) on each player. That INDEX CARD becomes a "one-player sportsboard."

The INDEX CARD will include:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - INDEX CARD - WHAT TO INCLUDE - (BASEBALL)

1. Player's name
2. Number
3. Position
4. Biographical data
5. Room for statistics...
   a. batting average
   b. home run and RBI
   c. doubles and triples
   d. stolen bases
   e. pitching record
   f. strikeouts and base on balls
   g. wild pitches
   h. fielding percentage, errors, assists, and times hit into double play

ILL. # 7

The INDEX CARDS should be brought up to date after each game. These INDEX CARDS can also have a separate line for what the player has done in each game of the three-game series.

This gives you "fingertip" information. You could use the card to supply a statement like this:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - INDEX CARD - HOW TO USE

1. "Bill Jones coming to bat for Syracuse. Jones is 4 of 9 in the series including a double, home run and four RBI. He was 2 for 4 last night against Oriole righthander Fuzzy Throckmorton, and 2 for 5 against Walter Mathewsome in the series opener."

ILL. # 8

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You use the INDEX CARDS to supplement the basic information in the SCOREBOOK.

For example: As you give the batting order from the SCOREBOOK, **you should arrange your INDEX CARDS in the same order**. So, when the player comes to bat, you can say:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - USE OF INDEX CARDS AND SCOREBOOK TOGETHER

"Jones again leading off for Syracuse. He'll be followed by Muscrat Donnelly and Methuselah Epstein in the bottom of the fifth inning, Syracuse leading the Duluth Orioles, 3-0. All three runs came in the first inning when Jones blasted a three-run homer into the upper deck in right field off Walla Walla Smythe."

ILL. # 9

After Jones bats, then you go to the "Muscrat Donnelly" card and move Jones' card to the back of the starting nine index cards.

You will find this to be quick, easy, and comfortable to work with during any baseball broadcast.

MISCELLANEOUS INFORMATION.

In addition to the Sportsboards, Scorebooks, and Index Cards, you may have much more information at hand. You can prepare this on 8x11 sheets, or additional 4x6 index cards, (3x5 are actually too small to really be effective).

This information may include material such as:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - MISCELLANEOUS INFORMATION TO INCLUDE

1. Standings.
2. Series rivalry.
3. Upcoming schedules.
4. Other games tonight.
5. Streaks, trends, and unusual notes you want to bring into the broadcast if you have time.

ILL. # 10

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Remember---you will almost always prepare much more information than you can use in a given broadcast---if you have done your preparation correctly.

HOW TO PREPARE.

In Phase One, you were given much insight into the GREAT IMPORTANCE of preparation. **This cannot be overemphasized.** If you think you have done enough---you probably haven't. Eventually, you will learn exactly what type of information you need, but let's again take time to go through some of the information and where to get it.

The obvious things like rosters, height, weight, school, etc. are obtainable from the school or teams involved. At the high school level, your contact for that information will almost always be: THE COACH.

THE COACH.

The coach at the high school level is usually his/her own sports information person. The coach is the one who local newspaper/radio/television reporters talk to about the team, the players, the lineups, the rosters, the starters, the suspensions, the injuries. **Get to know your COACH.** Find out the best time of day/night to contact him/her. You must realize the COACH is probably teaching other classes, or may even be a part-time coach who is in some other business, or may even teach at a different high school.

WORKING WITH THE COACH.

Contact the COACH early on and introduce yourself. Tell him/her what game(s) you will be broadcasting (taping) and tell him/her your needs. MOST COACHES will be cooperative with you and will help you out. But, you must **work with them** and realize they are not all "public relations" oriented.

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They may be gruff, shy, reluctant, a little skeptical about you and the information you might share with "the other team." **Be sure to tell them that anything you learn from them is strictly for your broadcast and not for sharing with the "other team."** Believe me, some coaches are very paranoid when it comes to talking with the press, so it is your diplomacy and your tact that will probably have to win some of them over to you.

If they are rude, curt, or brusque, don't reply in kind. Be a professional. Be courteous but state your needs and desire to work with them in helping you to prepare for an objective broadcast that will flatter both teams and coaches.

WHEN TO CONTACT THE COACH.

Don't wait until the day before the game to call the coach. Make your contacts early and follow up on them, even if it is just to call to say hello and make sure there haven't been any late changes to the roster.

THE TEAM ROSTERS.

Speaking of the roster. Go over the roster with the coach to make sure it is up to date. Any number changes? Any additions or deletions? How to pronounce names that seem unusual or where you have any doubt. Write them out phonetically to be sure you will pronounce them correctly.

Check with the coach about:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - WHAT TO ASK THE COACH

1. How has the team been practicing?
2. How have they "rebounded" from their last defeat (or win)?
3. What are the keys to defeating their next opponent?
4. What tendencies they have seen that they must overcome?
5. How to prepare for this opponent?

ILL. # 11

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TAKE NOTES as you are listening. BE A GOOD LISTENER. Try to "read between the lines."

For example:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - LISTENING AND ASKING THE COACH IMPORTANT QUESTIONS

The coach might give you a lineup that doesn't include their leading scorer. You need to ask:

1. "Why isn't Jones starting?"
2. "Where is Jones?"
3. "Has he been suspended? Why?"

ILL. # 12

Don't be belligerent---Just ask the question. Your listeners will want to know. So should you.

Quite often the COACH will have the statistics for the team. Sometimes they don't keep very good ones, so you have to ask for what they do have.

STATISTICS - WHO TO CONTACT.

Now, if the COACH doesn't have the stats, what do you do? Well, contact local newspaper reporters who regularly cover the team. Most of the time they will have their own stats, or at least key stats on the key players. Contact those reporters---get to know them.

Keep the telephone numbers of the coaches, reporters, athletic officials you will be dealing with. Get on the mailing list of leagues and conferences, in addition to the schools you cover.

Attend practices on occasion. Be sure to follow-up with telephone calls to indicate your interest. Let them get to know you, to know your objectivity, your sincerity, your goal to do the best job possible.

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This follow-up and follow through should apply to your performance whether you are doing the games for practice, for $5, as an intern, as a local sports broadcaster or as a highly paid professional. **Maintain your contacts.**

SPORTS INFORMATION DIRECTORS ("SIDS").

The SIDS are vital links of information at the college, university, and professional levels. They may go under other titles:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - TITLES - SOURCES OF INFORMATION

1. Public Information Officer.
2. Publicity Director.
3. Public Relations Director.
4. Media Relations Director.
5. Media and Broadcast Director.

ILL. # 13

Some community colleges have them, some don't. Rarely, if ever, does a high school have someone in this capacity. That's why you go to the COACH.

Where there is a "professional" contact at a school or with a professional sports franchise, contact those people. Get to know them, to let them know you. Tell them your goals in preparing for the broadcast (tape). **Invariably, if you approach them in an adult, professional manner**, they will provide the information you need.

You will be asking for team rosters, records, press books, press guides, biographical data of players and coaches, information about the school, school colors, etc. They are paid to make this information available to the press in quick, easy form.

Just be prepared to tell them your needs and why.

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For example:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - MAKE CLEAR YOUR NEEDS

1. It may be the arranging of broadcast location at the game.
2. Where to hook up telephone lines for your broadcast?
3. Scheduling interviews with the coach, players, or other personnel.

ILL. # 14

"Court" these people because they can make your job much easier.

PRESS GUIDES.

If you are able to get access to press guides, your job of preparation will be much easier.

Press guides will have:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - PRESS GUIDE INFORMATION

1. Team records.
2. Team history.
3. Individual records (we hope).
4. Coaching biography.
5. Player biographies.
6. School colors.
7. Nicknames.
8. Information about the school.
9. Statistics (last season).

ILL. # 15

On the other hand, they may be so "skimpy" as to almost be a waste of time. They might show the roster in alphabetical order only. You need a NUMERICAL ROSTER, especially in football. If there aren't any NUMERICAL ROSTERS, you may have to make them up yourself from the alphabetical roster, assuming it has numbers listed somewhere on the roster. I have done this on more than one occasion.

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Another way of tracking down rosters, incidentally, is to contact a team that has played this team before. Quite often, there was a game program roster that might give you a "leg up" on your own roster.

PRESS RELEASES.

Get on the mailing list of leagues or conferences that are affiliated with your team. They should send out weekly releases giving scores, highlights, upcoming games, stats, and other information that will be helpful in preparing for your broadcast. Again, you should contact the office early to get on that list. Keep after them if they forget to send a mailing to you. But, be polite and be professional.

You can't use all the material you receive, so pick out the information that's important. Don't worry about the last place team in the league if you are broadcasting a game between teams #1 and #2 unless the last place team was last week's opponent or maybe next week's opponent.

Make your preparation time count by collecting information that will be useful in making your broadcast a better one. Don't clutter it up with extraneous material.

For example:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - UNNECESSARY MATERIAL

1. "Team #1 leads the league with a 10-2 mark and is coming off a 66-55 win over Santa Fe Downs. Team #2 has a 9-3 record and was upset by Dinky High, 77-76, in overtime last Wednesday. *The Mulberry Falcons , 1-11, are idle tonight".*

ILL. # 16

The last line, by itself, has nothing to do with the game you are broadcasting. This is an obvious example, but it should be helpful in making you analyze just what information you have and if you really need to use it.

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If you are doing major college or professional sports, your real job will be to sift through TOO MUCH material. You will get tons of it from the National Football League, NFC West, NFC East, AFC West, AFC East, etc. Your job here would be to sort through all of that and collect information important to your game and players. Anything else would be used in reserve in case of a long delay in your broadcast. A natural disaster for example.

FILES (CARD, NEWSPAPER, PRESS RELEASES).

At the start of each season, you should start setting up files for the schools you are broadcasting for (schools/teams, etc.) Those files should be updated as each game is played.

For example:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - FILES - WHAT TO COLLECT

1. Key stats.
2. Game stories.
3. Anecdotes.
4. Highlights.
5. Coach's comments.
6. Player development or injuries.
7. Card files on individual players and teams.
8. Stats of every game, if possible.

ILL. # 17

Your local papers will probably have game stories and stats each week of the season.

Quite honestly, you may have several files that are being maintained about the league, the teams, the upcoming opponents and even other leagues they might have to pair off within the playoffs. Eventually, you are going to have many files but they will give you the information you will need. Sometimes only one sentence of information is relevant, but at least you will have it.

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One school, for which I was doing a variety of broadcasts, added a basketball player from the freshman team after I had seen them play. He scored a three-pointer in his first game in the final seconds to give his team the victory. Six weeks later, I had the opportunity to use that one-liner when I again broadcast that team's game against another opponent.

The idea is to collect information, catalog it, keep it up to date and then to use it where appropriate.

For example, using the player in the situation above:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - USE OF INFORMATION

1. "Downtown Eddie into the game for the Beardogs, replacing Sylvester Marquis at guard. 3:22 to go in the first quarter, Beardogs leading the Snapdragons, 26-23. Eddie brings the ball into right frontcourt, to Smith along the right baseline, now back to Eddie at the point. Eddie from three-point range on the way---goood! Eddie hits the three-pointer to tie the game 26-26. Just six weeks ago, Eddie made his varsity debut a winning one, also with a three-pointer to beat XYZ High, 44-43."

ILL. # 18

FROM PACE TO PREPARATION.

Regardless of the sport, you must be aware of PACE, ENERGY, VOICE, ENUNCIATION/DICTION, DELIVERY AND PREPARATION.

We have said a lot about preparation---for good reason. **Prepare, prepare,** then **prepare** more.

Now, a word about the other categories which Al Epstein also discussed in Phase One.

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PACE.

A comfortable "medium" tempo is what you should be striving for. There are various reasons for medium tempo as opposed to fast or slow.

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - PACE - MEDIUM TEMPO

1. A medium tempo allows you AND the listener the opportunity to evaluate what you are saying. You have a listening audience that has only your view point, your words to tell them what's going on during a radio broadcast. If you talk too fast, you leave the listener behind. If you talk too slow, they turn the dial or go to sleep. So, a medium energetic tempo is the compromise.
2. As Al Epstein pointed out in Phase One, you can always play catch-up but don't "race" to catch-up with the play. Other reasons for a medium tempo: It gives you a chance to take a breath...to reflect on what has just happened and then to discuss it briefly, or at a timeout.
3. Still another reason. You are going to be on the air from 2 to 4 hours and will need to PACE YOURSELF from an energy standpoint. If you start off too fast, you will probably run out of energy before the third quarter, or sixth inning, etc. If you start off too slowly, you will find it difficult to pick up the tempo during the game.
4. Thus, a medium tempo gives you the opportunity to stay energetic, controlled, physically strong and also gives the audience a chance to stay with you.

ILL. # 19

WORD ECONOMY.

In Play-by-Play, the idea is WORD ECONOMY---use words that fit the situation. Don't race through the broadcast. In newspaper work, we would call this EDITING the copy. What you become on the air is a "broadcast editor" of words and phrases.

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For example:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - WORD ECONOMY

1. "Jones' turnaround 15-footer from the free throw line is good." This tells us who shot, how far, where from, gives us the place on the floor and tells us it was good. **Good word economy.**
2. "Jones has the ball at the top of the free throw line. He turns to his left, head fakes, jumps in the air and shoots. The basket is good." **Many words---far too many.**

ILL. # 20

Just use the words that describe what went on so you don't fall behind. As you broadcast more games, learn the **word economy** that fits the situation. Learn the phrasing and phraseology that will allow you to stay with the action at a comfortable tempo.

ENERGY.

This ties into the previous discussion. Controlled energy and excitement (where it's appropriate) are dual goals. If you become hysterical, people will turn you off---mentally and physically--by pushing the button on the radio. But, you must sound interested and involved in the broadcast. A sense of humor is wonderful if you can use it naturally. **The Key: Controlled Energy.**

ENUNCIATION/DICTION.

This was discussed in Phase One and this is another reminder. Work with your mouth muscles. Round off the words and syllables, make them crisp. The faster you talk, the more you have to be aware of HOW you are saying words. **Can they be understood by the listener? Can you understand what you are saying?**

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Take a breath, push the sound out from your diaphragm and enunciate words clearly. The listener assumes you to be articulate and intelligent about what you are doing. If you are slurring, mumbling, using "lazy mouth" (broadcast term for lazy habits), the listener will find another station in short order. If "lazy mouth" speech habits become apparent to you, or your instructor, it's time to get to work on them.

There are exercises one can practice to help clear up speech patterns, regionalisms, dialects and lazy speech. These will be discussed, if necessary, when your broadcast tapes are critiqued.

GENERAL BROADCAST PROBLEMS.

This is a category that is open-ended. By that, I mean that things will occur that you just can't imagine. Just doing a game into a tape recorder can present untold perils.

1. The tape recorder doesn't work.
2. The batteries are low, or dead.
3. The microphone battery dies during the broadcast. No burial, except for your broadcast!
4. The wrong tape speed is used.
5. The tapes are defective.
6. The tapes jam up and you have no spare tapes.

OTHER PROBLEMS.

1. You forget your spotting boards.
2. You forget your briefcase.
3. You forget to bring the rosters.
4. You are put into a physical environment in the middle of the stands.
5. It rains while you are sitting in the stands.
6. You forget to ask where the game is being played and wind up in Duluth!!
7. You come down with laryngitis before the game.
8. The coach cancels the pre-game interviews.
9. You get thrown into the swimming pool! (Al did, with his best suit on!)

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This list can go on for several pages and still not cover every eventuality. Believe us---things will go wrong---some of the time.

SURVIVAL KIT.

A "Survival Kit" will be discussed in great detail in Phase Four. But, you need to be thinking about the things you will need starting now.

This would include:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - BEGINNING SURVIVAL KIT

1. Different colored pens and pencils.
2. "White-out" to eliminate mistakes or correct rosters.
3. Backup batteries.
4. Index cards.
5. Scotch tape.
6. Masking tape.
7. Erasers.
8. Rule books.
9. Schedules.
10. A pocket calculator will be an immense help to you as you figure statistics.

ILL. # 21

Don't bring an adding machine. (A pocket calculator is small and easy to work with.)

COLOR COMMENTATOR.

This is an area that will be addressed in much more detail in Phase Four. However, there's a good chance you will want to work some of your "broadcasts" during this course with a partner.

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Guidelines to follow when working with a color commentator:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - COLOR COMMENTATOR

1. A color commentator or analyst, is someone who adds insight, (hopefully), to your play-by-play. It should not be "an echo" of what you say:

   If you say, "Great shot by Jones," the color commentator's next words shouldn't be, "Lou, that was a great shot by Jones."

2. The color commentator should pick up subtleties of the action, bring insight that can be fit into a very short time-frame, or that can be developed during a time-out.

3. THE PLAY-BY-PLAY and COLOR COMMENTATOR SHOULD NEVER BE TALKING AT THE SAME TIME. Cardinal rule No. 1. One person talks at a time. No exception. Anything else is confusing to listen to, makes for verbal clutter and destroys the broadcast.

4. Work out a "signal" system with your partner. You can point, or nod, or gesture, or give him a verbal cue that he should step in and make comments. You can also give similar cues that you need the "mic/mike" back so you can continue the play-by-play. On radio, the color commentator should not be talking if there is action for you to report.

5. The color commentator needs to play a "second banana" role. The main person is the play-by-play announcer in radio. You will see some exceptions in television coverage where a famous ex-coach is doing color and becomes the "star" of the show; but, this does not apply to most play-by-play situations.

6. All the color commentator has to do is to raise his/her hand a little to let you know they have something to say. Or, they raise a pencil, or tap you on the shoulder. It should be a subtle signal just to alert you. Then, if there is time, go ahead and toss it to him /her. (he/she must still get it back to allow your play-by-play).

7. A good play-by-play/color commentator tandem adds a great deal to a broadcast. A bad one wrecks it for everyone.

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REVIEW.

We have covered more details about sportsboards, use of statistics, equipment, press guides, press releases, use of newspapers, energy, pacing, enunciation, and color commentary. Please review Phase One and Phase Two to sharpen your thoughts for your next assignment.

ASSIGNMENT FOR PHASE TWO.

Broadcast (tape record) another game. Once again, baseball, basketball, football are the sports we are concentrating on, but if you want to do ice hockey, soccer, or volleyball, go ahead. Do your best to find a "live" game and go through the steps we have discussed in preparing for the game.

Again, the "fall-back" position would be a television game. If this is your only alternative, go for it. But, TURN THE SOUND DOWN on your TV set. We don't want to hear the announcer in the background while you are recording the game.

Please find what you consider to be the best 3, 4, or 5 **CONSECUTIVE** minutes of play-by-play action (UNEDITED). Again, you will learn from your mistakes and we will discuss them when we critique the tape. Also, have your SPORTSBOARD available for review.

That takes care of Phase Two.

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Blue & Gold

TEAM: DENVER DUCKS

OFFENSE

Run & Shoot

Record 6-4

COACH ARNIE HAYES 1st Year

SE/WR		T		G		C		G		T		TE	
18	6-1, 180, SR JOHN SMITH					50	RAY JONES						
32	5-11, 175, NR BILL JONES					57	LONG SNAPS CHARLIE ANTHONY						
24	5-11, 168, JR LEWIS JOHNSON												

KICKOFF RETURNS

116/234/496%
2,450 YDS
16 TD
13 INT.
67 LG/TD

QB

16	6-2, 165, SR ROD MOUNTAIN

FL-WB-WR

HOLDER_____

RB-FB

PUNTERS

RB-TB

PAT/FG/KK

BASKETBALL

COLORS
GREEN .
ORANGE

LOS ANGELES PELICANS
COACH: ROCKY GROUNDS
(3rd YEAR 50 - 21)

16 - 7 Overall
7 - 2 League
.Fast Break.
.High Post.

X 10 — Johnny Carnack	,F,6-7,185,SR	18.9, 6.7R, 4.0A, 26 HG, FG 47% FT 84.4%
X 14 (BLUE)	(GREEN)	(RED)
X 26		
X 30		
X 44		
XX 12 (BLUE)	(GREEN)	(RED)
XX 18		
XX 45		
II 8 (BLUE)	(GREEN)	(RED)
II 11		
II 21		
II 32		

PLAY-BY-PLAY SPORTSCAST TRAINING

PHASE THREE

AN INTRODUCTION AND PRESENTATION OF INTERVIEWING TECHNIQUES... AND, THE SPORTS REPORT

AUTHORED BY

LOU RIGGS

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PHASE THREE

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PLAY-BY-PLAY - SPORTSCAST TRAINING
PHASE 3 - BY LOU RIGGS

AN INTRODUCTION AND PRESENTATION OF INTERVIEWING TECHNIQUES...AND, THE SPORTS REPORT

Again, congratulations. You have completed the first two phases of Play-by-Play Sportscast Training. Fun? Isn't it?

One of the most difficult things to do in broadcasting is THE INTERVIEW. Phase Three will discuss the art of interviewing, how to prepare, how to conduct the interview and how to "control" the interview.

Phase Three will also be an opportunity for you to show your sports reporting and writing skills with a two-minute sports show assignment.

THE INTERVIEW (FIVE MINUTES).

The FIRST requirement in interviewing is to be a GOOD LISTENER. A GOOD LISTENER is just that. You listen to what your guest is saying. Many beginning interviewers, and some who have been at it for a while, don't listen to what the guest is saying. That causes them to miss a great chance to "piggyback" onto an answer with a follow-up question.

Many "interviewers" don't interview. They make statements and HOPE the guest is alert enough to step in and make a statement or comment.

How many times have you heard something like this?:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - STATEMENT

1. "Bill, you pitched brilliantly tonight, striking out 10 men, walking only one and never falling behind on a hitter." End of statement. And, no question. ("Bill," hopefully, will be kind enough to step into the situation and say something---anything).

ILL. # 1

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ASK THE QUESTION.

Don't make statements unless you follow with a question. Let's take the same interview:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - ASK THE QUESTION

1. "Bill, you pitched brilliantly tonight, striking out 10 and walking only one. What was your "out" pitch tonight?"

ILL. # 2

Ideally, you will ask questions which are just long enough to draw out your guest. Let your guest do the talking. If you listen well, you will be able to follow up with questions that will help paint a broader picture of the game, the performance, what it means to the player, the team.

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - FOLLOW UP QUESTION

1. "Bill, you have now won four in a row for the Jack Rabbits. Is this the best streak you've ever had?"
   Again, a statement followed by a question. You have set up the question and then followed through with one that fits the context. Now, Bill's response might be:

   "Well, Al, I once won 25 in a row in Little League."

   Okay, do you leave it at that? Or do you go on to ask an obvious follow-up such as?:

2. "Bill, obviously this isn't Little League, so what about professionally? Ever pitched better for a longer period of time?"

   We have gone back to the origional question and tied it togther with the original thought...what about the pros?

ILL. # 3

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There are several types of interview situations. We'll comment on them briefly.

SPONTANEOUS INTERVIEW.

You don't know who you're going to interview until the last minute. Suddenly, the athletic director is brought over to you to talk about a fund-raising event. Or, the new track coach is in the gym tonight and might be a good guest. You have to listen to your guest carefully and follow-up his/her answers as you go along because you know very little about the event or person with whom you are talking. These are REAL CHALLENGES.

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - GENERAL QUESTIONS.

The athletic director is your last minute guest. One question you can always ask is:

1. "What did you think of team X's performance in the first half."

   Or, you might ask::

2. "What are the prospects for spring sports teams for XYZ Tech?"

   Or, if you know a special fund raising event is coming up soon, you might ask:

3. "Tell us about the special football benefit you have coming up next week."

ILL. # 4

SIDELINE INTERVIEW.

Usually, you pick out someone to interview as the game is in progress. You may only have 30 seconds, or maybe 60 seconds to introduce your guest, ask a question or two and then get off the air.

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - SIDELINE INTERVIEW/GENERAL QUESTIONS

A player has limped off the field and you ask the team trainer:

1. "What is the injury to Johnny Ebenezer?"

   Or, you might ask:

2. "When will you know the extent of Johnny Ebenezer's injury?"

   And, you can follow up with:

3. "Will he be able to return to the game today?"

ILL. # 5

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PRE-GAME INTERVIEW.

This is usually with the coach and is fairly well structured. You have time to prepare your thoughts and questions. These interviews usually last three or four minutes, but some pre-game shows may go on for 10 or 15 minutes. The shorter the interview, the more specific you have to be in your questions. The longer the interview, the more you can delve into team goals, coaching philosophies, player injuries, etc.

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - PRE-GAME INTERVIEW/GENERAL QUESTIONS

1. "Coach, how has your team practiced for this game?"
2. "Coach, are there any lineup changes?"
3. "What kind of offense does team A run?"
4. "How will you defend against their passing attack?"

ILL. # 6

HALF-TIME INTERVIEW.

Somewhat similar to the SPONTANEOUS INTERVIEW in that you may not know who your guest is going to be until shortly before the interview. On the other hand, you might have lined up the guest earlier in the evening, or several days in advance. You may have as much as five minutes for this type of interview.

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - HALF-TIME INTERVIEW/GENERAL QUESTIONS

You might be visiting with a coach from another school (team) who is scouting the game. You could ask:

1. "What do you think of team B's effort in the first half?"
2. "What kind of problems will they present your team?"
3. "How will you try to stop their big center, Abner Tallperson?"

These are all clear questions, to the point, and that's what you should strive for in your interview.

ILL. # 7

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POST-GAME INTERVIEW.

Usually with a coach or player of the winning team, but sometimes from the losing team. Winning players and coaches are easy to interview. Losing players and coaches are sometimes a wee bit testy and you need to watch how you phrase your questions. Some guests are easy to interview and make your job very easy. Others will be a real pain in the neck. Eventually, you learn why some players are rarely guests on post-game shows and why others are very popular. It's usually called "class."

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - POST-GAME INTERVIEW/WITH THE COACH

1. "Coach, what was the turning point?"
2. "Coach, why did you switch from a man-to-man to a 3-2 zone defense in the second half?"
3. "Coach, describe this effort compared with last week's effort."

ILL. # 8

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - POST-GAME INTERVIEW/WITH THE PLAYER

1. "Billy, what was the coach's instruction to the team in the last time-out?"
2. "Billy, how can you compare your intensity tonight with any other game this season?"
3. "How do you avoid a let down after such an emotional win tonight?"

ILL. # 9

These are all basic examples of questions you might ask, should ask, and should develop during your interviews. LISTEN TO THE ANSWER BEFORE JUMPING IN WITH YOUR NEXT QUESTION.

STUDIO INTERVIEW.

This is much more structured in the sense that this is your "ballpark." It's your studio, your engineer, your environment. You have control here over the elements. You set the stage, you determine when the show starts (if it's on tape) and you determine when and how it's going to close.

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The studio interview could be anywhere from 5 to 60 minutes, sometimes longer depending on the programming format. But, it is YOUR show. You have time to prepare questions and ideas of discussion. If it's an author, you should read the book. If it's an actor, you should review his/her movies, plays, television performances enough to be able to comment about them or ask questions.

INTERVIEW TECHNIQUE.

Once you have prepared for your interview, here are a few guidelines to help make the show flow.

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - INTERVIEW TECHNIQUES

1- Know who your guest is and what he/she does.
2- Tell them what the time frame of the interview is.
3- Give them the signal you will use if you have to close out the interview.
4- Make sure your audio levels are equal for both speakers (you and your guest).
5- NEVER, NEVER LET THE GUEST HOLD THE MICROPHONE.
6- If you have just one microphone, YOU HOLD ON TO IT FOR YOUR LIFE.
7- If you do let the guest take the microphone, you may never get it back. Tell your guest you will hold on to the microphone.
8- If you are running out of time, tell the guest: "We've only got about 30 seconds left, what's your final thought about the law enforcement profession?"
9- Ask questions. Don't make statements without questions attached to them.
10- LISTEN TO THE ANSWERS.
11- Eliminate verbal "garbage" or "clutter."
(Examples would be, "uh huh," "uhms," "ahs," and, "ahs," "really," "that's interesting," "okay," and any other verbal noises you might be tempted to make during your guest's answers, or before you ask the next question. Just nod and that will be sufficient.
12- Don't be afraid of a "beat" or "second" of "dead air" after the guest has completed his/her answer to your question. This allows your guest and the listening audience the refreshing idea that you are THINKING before talking and not talking before thinking. A "beat" of "fresh" air is marvelous.

ILL. # 10

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INTERVIEW SET UP AND CLOSE.

THE SET UP: This should be very simple and straight forward.

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - THE SET-UP

1. "Good evening, this is People Watch and I'm Lou Riggs your host for the next half hour as we visit with Pepperdine basketball announcer Al Epstein. Al, how will the Waves do in the NCAA tournament?"

ILL. # 11

Short, to the point, and into the first question is less than 20 seconds. This should be a guideline to follow. It should not take you more than 20 seconds to introduce yourself, your guest and go to the first question. Then, ASK QUESTIONS.

THE CLOSE.

You shouldn't need more than 20 to 30 seconds to close out a five-minute interview.

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - THE CLOSE

1. "I'd like to thank Pepperdine basketball announcer Al Epstein for coming by today on People Watch. Next week, my guest will be Denver Duck head coach Arnie Hays. Until next time, this is Lou Riggs, thanks for listening and good night."

ILL. # 12

That should take care of it. Again, thanks, to the point, and close it out.

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STRUCTURE OF THE SHOW.

Obviously, you have the open and close. In between, you will have about 4:15 (four minutes and 15 seconds) of interview time. Use it with short, to the point questions. Listen to the answers, give a "beat" to think, then follow up with a question about the answer you have just heard, or move on to the next area you want to cover.

A frequently asked question by students: "Should I write out a list of questions and ask them from a sheet of paper?" Yes and no.

"**YES**," is the answer to writing out a list of questions as you begin your interview preparation. "**NO**," is the answer once the interview starts. Do not "read" your questions. The interview will sound "readee" and stilted.

However, you do want to jot down areas you want to cover during the interview:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - PHRASES OR KEY WORDS

1. Discuss injuries.
2. Line-up changes.
3. Team morale.
4. Player development.
5. Trends in the business.

ILL. # 13

That's all you really need to help you remember the areas you want to cover during the interview. You may not cover everything, so be sure to highlight the most important areas before you begin the interview.

Then, go for it.

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INTERVIEW DO'S AND DON'TS

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - INTERVIEW DO'S AND DON'TS

1. Do tell the guest the length of the show, the objectives of the interview and how you are going to signal him/her that you need to close out the show.
2. Do tell them that this will or won't be edited. Ideally, it won't be. You should strive for the best effort with one take.
3. Don't let go of the microphone if you only have one.
4. Don't tell them specifically what you are going to ask. But, respect them if they say something is "off the record." Don't bring it up.
5. "Don't ask "one last question." Invariably someone says, "One final question." And, then they ask another one. Or that "one final question" comes too late in the interview and causes the show to run too long.

ILL. # 14

INTERVIEW ENVIRONMENT.

For the purpose of this interview, find a quiet room, office, place of business, whatever. Ask them to cut off the telephones so you won't be interrupted during the interview. Ask them to have the assistant or secretary or whomever, not to interrupt. Then, when you roll tape, it should be for five minutes with no tape stops, no edits.

SPORTS SHOW (Two Minutes).

This will be a straightforward sports show. Take a local newspaper sports section of any day and rewrite the sports copy for broadcast purposes.

Use different stories. Don't make it just a long list of college basketball scores, for example. You might start off with the major sports story in your town, then go on to other important results or developments nationally or internationally.

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You should have a blend of stories: baseball, basketball, football, tennis, hockey, horse racing, etc.

DO NOT COPY NEWSPAPER STORIES WORD FOR WORD. Writing for print is very different than writing for broadcast purposes. Print can be wordy, convoluted and involved. Broadcast writing must be sharp, to the point.

A newspaper story might begin this way: "The Denver Ducks, led by third year coach Arnie Hays, are in the throes of a major losing streak that has gone on for a month now, finally reaching five games with a 34-15 loss at Houston last night."

A broadcast would sound something like this: "Denver continued its losing ways, dropping a 34-15 decision at Houston last night. It was Denver's fifth straight loss."

The goal behind the assignment is to give you a chance to see what the challenge of writing for the ear (broadcast) is like compared to writing for the eye (print).

Take your time, work with the copy and send in your two minute-sports show along with your five-minute interview.

YOUR ASSIGNMENT FOR PHASE THREE.

Record a five-minute interview with someone in your community you think would be an interesting guest, preferably someone in sports, (but doesn't have to be). No edits, no tape stops. Have an OPEN and a CLOSE. (If five minutes is not convenient, do a THREE-minute interview as an alternative).

An additional assignment is a two-minute sports show, rewritten for broadcast puposes. Again, no edits and no tape stops. Have an OPEN and CLOSE.

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PLAY-BY-PLAY SPORTSCAST TRAINING

PHASE FOUR

ADVANCED PLAY-BY-PLAY

AUTHORED BY

AL EPSTEIN

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PLAY-BY-PLAY - SPORTSCAST TRAINING
PHASE 4 - BY AL EPSTEIN

ADVANCED PLAY-BY-PLAY

HANDLING MISTAKES IN A BROADCAST.

Welcome to Phase Four! In Phase One we discussed the basic fundamentals of PBP, in Phase Two a comprehensive look at play-by-play, and in Phase Three an informative discussion about interviewing technique and sports reporting.

At this stage of the course, you have broadcast a number of games and possibly delivered that perfect sportscast!?!

Well- - -maybe one mistake! Two? Three? Okay- - -we all make mistakes, especially when you are talking continuously for 2-3 hours during a broadcast. There are just too many variables- - -and besides- - -we are all human!

It is alright to make a mistake- - -the wrong player scoring, identifying the wrong team, or stumbling over words.

During the course of a broadcast mistakes will be made, but a key to being a good sportscaster is **how you handle these mistakes**. This takes practice, time, and experience. Have some patience.

There are a number of rules to remember when making a mistake:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - RULES WHEN MAKING A MISTAKE

1. Have an awareness that you have made a mistake.
2. If you have made the wrong call, correct it and move on. **Do not keep talking about the mistake.**
3. Do not guess. This makes you vulnerable to a mistake. You either know or don't know- - -you are the "expert" on the air. You are authoritative, prepared, and knowledgeable. The listening audience expects this.
4. If the situation calls for it, make light of a mistake- - -add some humor, have fun with it.
5. If you are "totally lost," confused, behind the action, or possibly going too fast- - -**pause**- - -1) "step back" from the microphone,2) take a deep breath, 3) relax, 4) organize your thoughts, 5) and then continue. (This can cause a moment of "dead air" or silence.)

ILL. # 1

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It's alright to have 5-10 seconds of "dead air". This happens to all of us!

Here are some examples of how to **correct** a mistake:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - CORRECTING THE MISTAKE

1. "Jones scores on the driving lay-up- - -**make that Smith**- - -25-22, LA leads, 6:19 to go in the first half....Smith has 10 points."
2. Do not say, "I **thought** Jones picked up the foul (Smith was also near where the foul occurred)." Don't guess by saying, "I thought (believe, maybe , or guess) the foul was on Jones or Smith." **Just say**: "The foul was on Jones- - -make that Smith who picked up the personal."

ILL. # 2

Just remember to correct the mistake and continue. Again, try not to guess. When you use the terms- - -"I thought," "I guess," "I believe," or "maybe"- - -you leave yourself "open" to a mistake by sounding like you are unsure of yourself.

When a play does occur that you're unsure of (a foul, score, or rebound, etc.), you can also "work around" or talk about "other things" in the game until you are sure.

Here is an example of how to do this:

PBP-ST - ILLUSTRATION - "WORKING AROUND" MISTAKES

1. "Jones drives into the lane and is fouled." (At this point in the game you do not know who committed the personal foul).

   You can "work around" this by saying: "Jones drives into the lane and is fouled. Nice drive by Jones; 25-22, LA leads, 6:19 left in the first quarter. Jones did a good job of taking the ball strong to the basket." (By now you're sure of the call after watching the official give the signal and/or the scoreboard establishing the personal and team foul).

   Then continue by saying: "Carl picks up his 1st personal; the 3rd team foul against LA.; Jones shooting two shots."

ILL. # 3

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Remember, try not to guess---and if you are unsure---wait until you know. This takes practice and experience recognizing these situations.

WORKING WITH YOUR PARTNER.

When a mistake occurs while working with your partner (color commentator), try and not correct the person on the air, making him/her "look" awkward.

What you should do is let the person who made the mistake, either the color commentator or the play-by-play announcer, correct himself/herself.

If too much time has not elapsed, your partner can write a note or the person may realize the mistake---and correct it.

Remember, you are a team working together. You both want to sound good; but, if one person "sounds bad" ---- you both "sound bad." Again, work together and help each other during the broadcast.

THE COLOR COMMENTATOR.

The role of the color commentator is to enhance the broadcast by adding specific and important information, while interacting with the play-by-play announcer. The color commentator, like the play-by-play announcer, has to prepare for the game by reading newspapers, talking to coaches and players, and studying line-ups and background information.

The color commentator, while talking in a natural delivery, must be specific and concise, speaking "in and out" of the broadcast and not continue talking during the "important" action of the game.

This takes practice and experience to organize your thoughts between each play, while interacting with the play-by-play announcer.

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WORKING TOGETHER.

Occasionally, you may be working together for the first time on a broadcast; or you may have announced a few games with each other in the past---in this case you should develop a "signal system" allowing one or the other to speak.

For example, the color commentator, when having something to say, can "tap" the play-by-play announcer's arm or wave a pencil, thus avoiding both from talking at the same time during the broadcast. **Two of you should never be talking at the same time.**

WHEN TO TALK (COLOR COMMENTATOR).

There are practical times for the color commentator to speak (basketball may be the most difficult because of the constant, fast paced action).

Here are some ideas when the color commentator should talk during basketball:

PBP-ST - ILLUSTRATION - PRACTICAL TIMES TO SPEAK - BASKETBALL

1. When the ball is in the backcourt.
2. When play is stopped (a time-out or the ball is out-of-bounds).
3. When a player is shooting at the free-throw line.

ILL. # 4

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Baseball and football are easier because there is time between each play. Here are some ideas what the color commentator should observe and talk about during a game:

PBP-ST - ILLUSTRATION - COLOR COMMENTATOR - OBSERVATIONS

1. **What is happening in the game.**
   a. Observing each team and players.
   b. Is a team or player dominating in rebounding, scoring, defense or offense, etc.
   c. Type of defense or offense.

2. **Why something is happening in a game.**
   a. "The fastbreak is working because LA is outrebounding Boston and getting the outlet pass to midcourt quickly."
   b. "The rushing game is excellent because of a big offensive line that averages 6-4, 255 pounds."

3. **Focus on individuals in the game; maybe the sidelines. Observe and analyze one player and watch him/her for a few plays.**
   a. "Jones has been good on the boards; he has been getting great position under the basket."
   b. "Great running by Smith, he has good quickness and able to get outside...he runs the 40 in 4.5."

4. **Be specific in your observations.**
   a. "Jones has been scoring a lot tonight; he has 20 points.
   b. "Smith has been outstanding; he has scored 2 touchdowns and gained 105 yards in the game."

5. **Have your own information and observations.**

6. **Listen to your partner during the broadcast.**

ILL. # 5

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THE DON'TS OF THE COLOR COMMENTATOR

Here are some ideas what the color commentator should not do during a broadcast:

PBP-ST - ILLUSTRATION - COLOR COMMENTATOR - THE DON'TS

1. Don't repeat what the play-by-play announcer has just said.
   a. PBP - "Jones has been excellent tonight scoring 20 points."
      CC - "That's right Bill, Jones has been excellent; he has 20 points."

2. Don't constantly talk about the officiating---berating the officials.

3. Don't use too many words; Don't be wordy. Remember to come "in and out" quickly.

4. Don't generalize too much. Stay away from "good," "great," or "outstanding," **unless you are specific.**
   a. "Jones is having a great game---(he has 30 points and 10 rebounds).
   b. "Smith has been excellent running the ball---(he has carried the ball 20 times for 120 yards and 2 touchdowns)."

ILL. # 6

The color commentator is a very important part of any broadcast. He/she needs to be prepared, knowledgeable, informative, and professional.

TH...TH...THAT'S NOT ALL FOLKS!

The color commentator also may have to keep statistics, engineer the equipment at the game, or conduct interviews during the pre-game, half-time, or post-game shows.

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POINT OF REFERENCE - BRINGING INFORMATION INTO THE BROADCAST.

As a play-by-play announcer or color commentator, you will be giving information and statistics throughout the broadcast. You will refer to facts and stories about each player and team.

When you are preparing your material for the game, you will need to include information from the past, present, and the future. This is called "point of reference" information.

Here are some ideas about point of reference:

PBP-ST - ILLUSTRATION - POINT OF REFERENCE - WHAT TO INCLUDE

1. Current statistics for each team and player.
2. Future schedules - dates and times of games and broadcasts.
3. Present and past career and game statistics (averages, percentages, and highlights).
   a. "Jones with a career high 34 points, his previous high game was 32 last season against LA."
   b. "Boston averages 17 turnovers a game, they have 9 tonight in the first half; last year Boston turned the ball over just 12 times a game."
4. Past won and loss records.
5. History of the series between the two teams.
6. Past coaches and players of each team (standouts).
7. Records at "home" and on the "road" --- current and past.
8. Past individual performances against the same team.
9. League/conference history and records - defending league champs.
10. Past all-conference/league players - MVP - top scorers and rebounders in league.
11. Research current national statistics, ratings, and other league leaders.

ILL. # 7

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POINT OF REFERENCE - EXAMPLES.

a. "Boston has won 6 straight games; last year their longest winning streak was 13 games."
b. "Boston and LA split their two games last season. Boston will be at LA in 1996."
c. "Boston, last night, defeated LA 101-76; Boston has beaten LA four straight times dating back to last season."

You will have a tremendous amount of material. You should bring the information into the broadcast at different times, not trying to "force" all the material at once.

PBP-ST - ILLUSTRATION - DISTRIBUTING INFORMATION DURING THE GAME

1. **(Information)** - "32" Tom Jones - 6'2" 185 lbs. Sr. LA forward - 1991 -ave. 21 ppg. 13 rpg. MVP of league - wants to play in Europe. Studying to be a doctor - married with 1 child - girl - 23 months old. This season - 22 ppg 10 rpg.

Examples:

a. **(Jones at free throw line)** - "Jones, a senior from LA; 22 points tonight; last year averaged 21 ppg; wants to play in Europe when he graduates."
b. **(The next time Jones is at the free throw line)** - "Jones, averaging 22 ppg; married with 1 child---a baby girl; he has 28 pts. tonight as he makes both free throws."

ILL. # 8

This information adds a great deal to the broadcast. This comes with preparation and research, obtained from newspapers, press guides and releases, as well as talking with coaches and players.

The first half of any game is a good time to include your background information, statistics, and point of reference material for players and teams.

As the game progresses into the second half; you can still include point of reference information, but realize, **if the contest is close, stay with the game.** The drama, excitement, action, crowd, and the finish become the most important aspects of the broadcast.

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THE PRE-GAME SHOW.

The pre-game show will set the stage for the game. Depending on the format, it will vary in length from 5 minutes to 30 minutes before each contest. The producer, program director, or general manager will decide how much time the pre-game show will be.

Here are some ideas on what the pre-game show should include:

PBP-ST - ILLUSTRATION - PRE-GAME SHOW - FORMAT

1. A 2-3 minute "open."
2. A 7-8 minute interview - usually a coach, but could include a second guest, a player.
3. Commercials, 3-5 minutes, throughout pre-game.
4. Re-set the stage of the game, then give the starting line-ups.
5. Play-by-play and color commentator will talk before the start of the game. If there is no color commentator, the play-by-play announcer must be prepared to talk about the game:
   a. Possible strengths and weaknesses of each team.
   b. Keys to victory for each team.
   c. Important statistics.
6. Start of the game.

ILL. # 9

Again, the length of the pre-game and the format will vary with each producer.

THE OPEN.

The "open" begins the broadcast by setting the stage of the game. Although this will vary, it usually includes the following:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - THE OPEN

1. Welcoming the listening audience.
2. Who you are.
3. Where the game is from - arena or gym and city.
4. The two teams and their respective leagues.

ILL. # 10

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EXAMPLE:

A VERY PLEASANT GOOD EVENING EVERYONE.....BOSTON BASKETBALL IS ON THE AIR....FROM THE LA ARENA, IN LA.....I'M JOHN JONES ALONG WITH TOM SMITH....AND WE WELCOME YOU TO TONIGHT'S BASKETBALL GAME.....THE PILGRIMS OF BOSTON, MEMBERS OF THE EASTERN CONFERENCE.....AND THE QUAKERS OF LA, MEMBERS OF THE WESTERN CONFERENCE.....

Again, you need to develop your own structure of the open, but include the basics that set the stage.

The next step, or the "body," will include the following:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - THE NEXT STEP - "THE BODY"

1. Basic information of each team.
2. This includes their records, overall and league.
3. The coaches of each teams....and how many years at the school.
4. Who each team played last and the results----when the game was played.
5. Highlight top performances in the most recent game.
6. The same steps for the second team.
7. For the visiting team, include some background about 2 or 3 of their players (scoring and rebounding averages, size, etc.).

ILL. # 10

The length and amount of information will vary, depending upon the amount of time in the pre-game show.

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EXAMPLE:

BOSTON, 25-19 ON THE SEASON AND 10-2 IN THE EASTERN CONFERENCE, COACHED BY JOE CARL, NOW IN HIS 10TH YEAR....THE PILGRIMS COME OFF A 108-103 VICTORY OVER NEW YORK LAST TUESDAY NIGHT.....JOE SCORED 25 POINTS AND ROOKIE SENSATION J.J. JACK ADDED 23 TO KEY THE VICTORY....THE SIXTH STRAIGHT WIN FOR BOSTON....BOSTON SHOT 53% FROM THE FIELD AND OUT REBOUNDED NEW YORK, 36-28.....

TONIGHT THE PILGRIMS TRAVEL TO THE WEST COAST TO FACE LA, 30-20 ON THE YEAR AND 11-5 IN THE WESTERN CONFERENCE, THE QUAKERS ARE COACHED BY F.F. JONES, IN HIS THIRD SEASON...THE QUAKERS DEFEATED SAN DIEGO, 102-99, LAST FRIDAY IN SAN DIEGO... LA WAS PACED BY S.S. SIMS, WHO SCORED 25 POINTS....

LA HAS EXCELLENT TALENT FEATURING 6-10 CENTER E.E. BLUE, WHO AVERAGES 22 PPG AND 10 RPG .....6-7 FORWARD D.D. WHITE, AN ALL-STAR LAST SEASON, AVERAGES 19 PPG AND 10 APG.....THIS IS A STRONG REBOUNDING TEAM...OUTBOARDING THEIR OPPONENTS BY 8 PER GAME...

The last segment of the open should include:

PBP-ST - ILLUSTRATION - THE LAST SEGMENT

1. Background about each team versus each other - series and past results.
2. The expected crowd.
3. Highlight each team again.
4. Your "outcue" followed by a "lead-in" to your pre-game interview(s).

ILL. # 11

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EXAMPLE:

BOSTON LEADS THE SERIES, 85-83, WITH LA AND BOSTON SPLITTING THEIR TWO MEETINGS LAST SEASON...BOSTON WINNING AT HOME...89-84...AND LA THE WINNER IN THE LA ARENA....105-100....

THE EXPECTED CROWD AT THE LA ARENA SHOULD NUMBER ABOUT 15,000.... AS BOSTON AND LA BATTLE FOR THE FIRST TIME THIS YEAR.....

AND WE'LL BE BACK WITH TONIGHT'S STARTING LINE-UPS AND THE OPENING TIP-OFF....BUT FIRST A VISIT WITH LA COACH F.F. JONES, RIGHT AFTER WE PAUSE FOR THESE MESSAGES....YOU'RE LISTENING TO LA BASKETBALL ON KBBB.....

After the open, commercials, and interviews, return and discuss the game until the start.

Remember, this is only a guideline for the pre-game and the open. Develop your own format and information that is comfortable for you.

THE HALF-TIME SHOW.

The half-time show will run approximately fifteen minutes in length and should include:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - THE HALF-TIME SHOW

1. Recap of first half - a general overview.
2. Individual statistics for each team.
3. Commercials will vary - allow 4 to 8 minutes total.
4. Interviewing a guest - allow 3 to 5 minutes (confirm your guest before the game).
5. Recap official statistics for each team (individual and team).
6. Set the stage for the second half and what to expect.
7. Introduce the starting line-ups for the second half.

ILL. # 12

Again, this is a guideline, with commercials, recap, and guests times varying.

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THE POST- GAME SHOW.

The post-game show is a complete recap and wrap-up of the game, usually about fifteen minutes in length, and should include:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - THE POST GAME SHOW

1. A recap of the game.
2. At the beginning, top scorers only.
3. A guest, either a coach or player (3-5 minutes).
4. Recap individual scoring for each team.
5. Review game.
6. Allow for several commercials.
7. Your "wrap-up."

THE "WRAP-UP" SHOULD INCLUDE:

1. Information about your next broadcast.
2. Final score.
3. Update team won-loss records.
4. Series between teams, if available.
5. People to thank.
6. Final score, again.
7. A last "sign-off," including your name, and your partner's.

ILL. # 13

EXAMPLE: THE "WRAP-UP"

OUR NEXT BROADCAST WILL BE TUESDAY, JANUARY 22ND, BOSTON VS. LA, FROM THE LA ARENA. OUR AIR TIME WITH THE PRE-GAME SHOW WILL BE 7:15 PM .....TIP-OFF AT 7:35 PM.....ONCE AGAIN THE FINAL SCORE: BOSTON 110, NEW YORK 101..BOSTON IS NOW 32-15 OVERALL...BOSTON LEADS THE SERIES 65-62.....SOME PEOPLE TO THANK ON TONIGHT'S BROADCAST.....OUR IN STUDIO ENGINEER AT KBBB, D.D. DOVE.....SPORTS INFORMATION DIRECTOR FOR BOSTON, L.L. JONES.....AT NEW YORK,

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C.C. RYDER .....KEEPING STATS AND ENGINEERING TONIGHT'S BROADCAST, S.S. SMALL.... EXECUTIVE PRODUCER ON BOSTON BASKETBALL IS M.M. CHECKERS.... ONCE AGAIN, THE FINAL SCORE....BOSTON 110, NEW YORK 101.....I'M T.T. THOMPSON ALONG WITH B.B. BARR,.....GOOD NIGHT EVERYONE.....

A play-by-play announcer should always be prepared and well organized during the pre-game, half-time and the post-game shows.

Once again, these are only guidelines for your use. Develop your own format for each show.

HOW TO BRING A SUBSTITUTION INTO A GAME.

During a game, especially in football and basketball, there will be a number of substitutions (players) in the contest. Knowing how to describe a substitution with background information is important.

When a player enters into the contest, **you need to give more than just his/her name. The play-by-play announcer should also give information about that player such as personal background (ht., wt., yr., hometown), or maybe a scoring or rushing average.**

Remember to identify the player entering the game, and if possible, whom he/she replaced.

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This should sound something like:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - SUBSTITUTIONS AND BACKGROUND INFORMATION

1. "Jones comes in for Boston, replacing Smith; Jones 6'2", 180 lbs., a senior from New York. Smith leaves with 10 pts."

2. "Jones checks in for Boston at wide receiver; replacing Smith, Jones runs the 40 in 4.4 seconds....he has caught 30 passes and scored 5 touchdowns."

3. "Jones come in to pitch for LA; Smith went 6 innings and allowed 3 runs.....Jones, from Hollywood, is 5-1 on the year and has struck out 50 in 40 innings."

ILL. # 14

Remember to vary the information about the player. He/she may enter the game a number of times.

Sometimes you may miss a substitution as he/she enters the game. This is alright. Just remember to identify the player when you do recognize the substitution.

You may also not see the player who left the game. This does happen, so just identify the player who came in and continue with your play-by-play.

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - MISSED SUBSTITUTION

1. "Smith to Jones---his jumper is no good-----**Jones just into the game for L.A. Jones, 6'2" 180 lbs., a senior from New York."**

ILL. # 15

The personal background gives the listener more information about who the substitution is, other than just his/her name. **It does make a difference.**

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A "THEME" FOR THE GAME.

Each sporting event has a "theme," sidelight, or an interesting story about the game.

It could be about a team, a player, or something noteworthy about the game; **but you need to decide what this is.**

This comes from your preparation and research of the game.

A "theme" could be:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - "THEMES"

1. A rivalry between two teams.
2. A team could have a long winning or losing streak.
3. A player could be on a "hot" or "cold" streak. .
4. A key match-up between two players.
5. A player or coach having a record game or closing in on school or league records.

ILL. # 16

You need to research a theme for each event and include it into the broadcast.

ENERGY IN THE BROADCAST.

The play-by-play announcer needs energy and enthusiasm during the broadcast---in a natural delivery.

Especially when you are young and/or inexperienced, your energy level tends to be uneven, uncontrolled and unnatural.

A big play or a sudden dramatic moment can create this unevenness.

As a play-by-play announcer you need to develop a gradual and natural level of energy when calling a play.

A practice exercise for this would be the "volume test" of counting 1 to 5. You should say "one" in a calm manner, and increase your energy until "five" is said enthusiastically. You should count, (1-2-3-4-5) gradually and build your energy in a natural projection. Practice this over and over.

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The common mistake is to "jump" from 1 to 5; talking, at first, in a normal voice, then almost shouting. This happens when there is an exciting play and you have this unnatural "jump" in your energy and excitement. It takes practice to deliver a big play in a natural, energetic fashion. Stay with it and have some patience.

THE "SURVIVAL KIT."

Every play-by-play announcer has a briefcase, but it's what's in it that counts!

Here is our list to "survive" as a sportscaster:

PBP-ST - ILLUSTRATION - "SURVIVAL KIT"

1. Pens and pencils - different colors.
2. Screwdriver (a sportscast is a "loose wire" away from being off the air).
3. Batteries (those tape recorders).
4. Audio tapes.
5. Separate microphone.
6. Cough drops (oh, those colds and winter sports)!
7. Aspirin ("loose wires" can bring on those headaches).
8. Pocket knife.
9. Scotch tape (for those windy football and baseball days).
10. Stop watch (time those commercials).
11. Calculator (need those averages).
12. Your business card (for that next job).
13. Pocket schedules (the next game is ?!).
14. Rule books (rule #53427.687549 is ?!!!!).
15. Masking tape.
16. "White out" (Liquid Paper).
17. Index cards & blank paper.
18. Rubber bands.
19. Tooth brush/Tooth paste & dental floss (It may be a long night in the Broadcast Booth after dinner).
20. Small pair of scissors.

ILL. # 17

You may have your own ideas, but we think we've covered most of it!

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GENERAL THOUGHTS.....

1. When meeting coaches, players, writers, sportscasters, and media people in general, **remember to always re-introduce yourself by name and who you are with (station, school, paper, etc.). This applies even if you're meeting them for the second, third, or fourth time.** This is how you develop relationships and a network in the industry. They meet people every day and can forget who you are. **A simple introduction and hello is all you need.**

2. Relax on the air....talk to one person....your wife, husband, or friend. Don't try and talk to the whole audience----this can be unnerving.

3. Don't drink soft drinks, coffee, or milk at least three hours before game time. This is bad for your voice. Don't eat ice cream either!

4. Don't make excuses on the air. There maybe poor lighting on the field/court. It could be very cold, raining, or foggy. You may have a light pole in your line of vision. **Work around these! The listening audience isn't interested in your problems. Be a professional.**

5. When memorizing players for a game---use numbers and individual characteristics (tall, wide, short, taped, knee, ankle, etc.)

6. Remember to let the audience know what direction a team is going - "Boston moving left to right." I wouldn't say, "left to right across your radio dial." What if the listener has a digital radio!

7. Remember to give the officials of the game in the first and second half.

8. Go to as many sporting events as you can. You want to be "seen" as much as possible.

9. Have a pre-game meal about four hours before game time. You are going to "put-out" a tremendous amount of energy during the broadcast. You will be very hungry after the game!

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10. Don't make excuses if it is difficult gathering information for a game. Sometimes information can be difficult to obtain; but, there are always ways to gather what you need for a game.

11. Always use a crowd microphone for the broadcast. Your use of the crowd is very important to a sportscast.

12. The play-by-play announcer and color commentator should not compete against each other. Work together!

13. The color commentator should not talk just to be on the air. He should have something informative to say.

14. Always write the final score on a piece of paper at the end of a game. The scoreboard is usually "turned-off" within about five minutes after the contest is over. You could possibly forget!

15. You should arrive at least 1 1/2 hours before game time to set up the equipment. Also, you need to familiarize yourself with the arena/field (scoreboard, your location, benches, out-of-bound lines, etc.).

HIGHLIGHTS - PHASE FOUR.

1. Handling mistakes.
2. Role of the color commentator.
3. Point of reference.
4. Pre-game, half-time, and post-game shows.
5. Substitutions.
6. Theme of the game.
7. Energy in a broadcast.
8. General thoughts.

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GENERAL PLAY-BY-PLAY EXAMPLES.

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - BASKETBALL PHRASING

1. "Jones dribbles into the lane, jumper from 5 feet is no good. Smith has the rebound and lays it in---25-19 LA leads, 5:25 remaining in the 1st quarter."

2. "Jones shooting two free-throws. He has 9 points tonight. Jones, a 75% free-throw shooter---as a team, Boston shoots 69%."

3. "Jones top of the key, guarded by Smith, Boston in a man-to-man defense."

ILL. # 18

PBP-ST - ILLUSTRATION - FOOTBALL PHRASING

1. "Wide to the right is Jones---wide to the left is Smith---1st and 10 at the Boston 25 yard line. Carl back to pass."

2. "Jones takes the snap, turns, hands-off to Smith---starts left, cuts inside at the 20 and downed at the 22."

3. "Jones will throw----fires deep over the middle; it's caught by Smith at the LA 20 yard line."

ILL. # 19

PBP-ST - ILLUSTRATION - BASEBALL PHRASING

1. "One out; Jones from the stretch; Smith takes his lead from 1st; the 1-1 pitch, fastball inside. Two balls and one strike on Carl."

2. "The outfield deep and straight away....3-1 LA, bottom of the 4th....the 2-2 pitch by Smith....."

3. "Jones delivers....Smith swings and hits it to deep left; Carl at the fence----it's a home run....."

ILL. # 20

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YOUR GOALS FOR PHASE FOUR.

Continue to develop your play-by-play calling, using the five fundamentals; **Score**, **Time**, **Who Has The Ball**, **Where The Ball Is**, **Pacing**, and to incorporate your color commentator. Work on bringing other information into the broadcast, besides just the game action. Also, in this phase, develop handling mistakes in a professional manner. Practice your pre-game, half-time, and post-game shows.

ASSIGNMENT - PHASE FOUR.

For Phase Four, your assignment will be a 3-5 minute play-by-play of a live game (high school, junior college, college, professional). Again, have your sportsboard available for review. Take your time, prepare, and do not edit the tape.

Practice, prepare, work hard, and have some fun!

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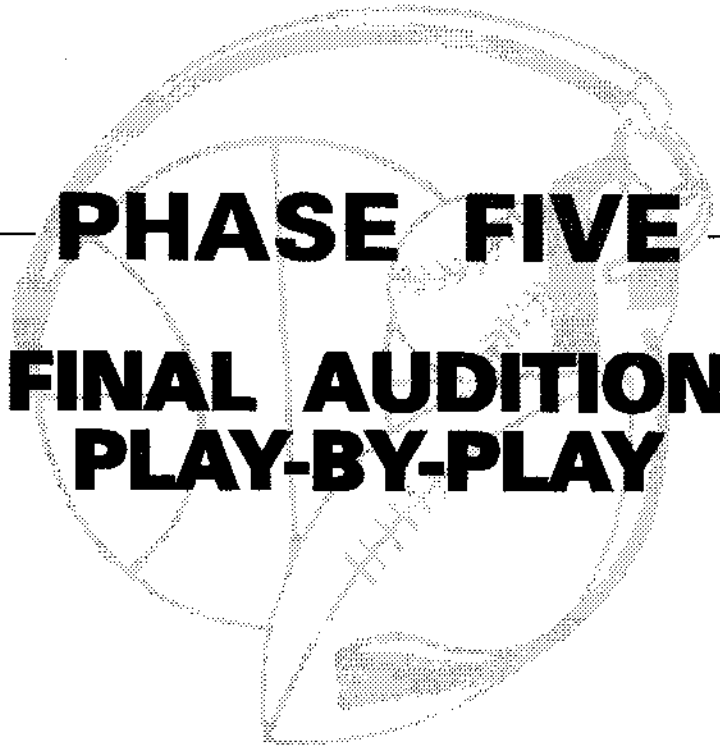
PLAY-BY-PLAY SPORTSCAST TRAINING



PHASE FIVE

FINAL AUDITION PLAY-BY-PLAY

AUTHORED BY

AL EPSTEIN

LOU RIGGS

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PLAY-BY-PLAY - SPORTSCAST TRAINING
PHASE 5 - BY AL EPSTEIN AND LOU RIGGS

FINAL AUDITION - PLAY-BY-PLAY

Congratulations. You have now moved through Phase Four and are ready for your final assignment.

In PHASE FIVE we will discuss a broad range of subjects---from your audition tape, resume', cover letter, and broadcast equipment to the future of sportscasting---this will complete our all-inclusive course on play-by-play announcing.

Thus far, we have taken a basic step-by-step look at play-by-play---starting with the fundamentals, a comprehensive view of play-by play, a discussion on interviewing and sports reporting, and advanced play calling. Now, in our last phase, we bring it all together with your audition tape.

THE AUDITION TAPE.

Your audition tape is one of the "keys" to securing a play-by-play position. It is the representation of your talent and ability, which will be listened to and/or viewed by that prospective employer.

Your audition tape should be about 3 to 5 minutes in length and begin with an exciting play (with a crowd background.) **Your first 30 seconds of the tape will be the most important.** You need to get the program director/general manager/producer's attention right from the start.

Remember, a station executive will hear a tremendous number of tapes, and he/she doesn't have the time to listen very long.

You need to "grab" his/her attention immediately. If they like what they hear, they will continue listening and/or contact you for more play-by-play tape.

Do not edit your tape---find the best 3-5 minutes. Be sure to have a clean, typed label with your name and phone number on the cassette.

Applying for a job is like anything else---there are 1,000 reasons why you will get hired---and 1,000 reasons why you won't.

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Don't get discouraged, just keep trying---you never know when you will land that next play-by-play announcing job. HOWEVER YOU HAVE TO MAKE IT HAPPEN!

YOUR RESUME'.

Your resume' is very important in securing a job. It says a lot about you, not only in its content, but the style---the way it is presented.

Your resume' should be no longer than one page and should be printed or typed.

Never send a handwritten resume'.

We have enclosed a sample resume'; but, keep in mind this is only a guideline.

Your resume' should include:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - RESUME'

1. Name.
2. Address.
3. Telephone number.
4. Some personal background - education, height, weight.
5. Highlight your experience with your most recent job first.

ILL. # 1

SEE RESUME EXAMPLE - NEXT PAGE

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RESUME' EXAMPLE

Larry Chucks
0000 Funster St.
Los Angeles, California 00000
(000) 111-1111

Education: **Bachelor of Arts Degree,** California State at Daffyville. Major: Radio and Television.

Experience: **Television**

4/86-present Station **KDDD-TV,** Oxnard, California

Play-by-play and Color Commentary for Doo-Wop Baseball. PBP and Color Commentary for local high school football and basketball.

Experience: **Radio**

9/84-present Station **KCCC**, Simi Valley, California

"Voice" of Neptune University Seashell Basketball. PBP and Color of live sportscasts of the Prep Game of the Week, football, basketball, and baseball.

8/83-11/85 Station **KZZZ,** Las Vegas, Nevada

PBP for Denver Duck Football. Public Address Announcer for Storyville University Basketball.

Experience: **Writing, Instruction, and Awards**

8/87-present **Sportscaster Camps of America,** Los Angeles, California. Counselor - Consultant.

9/85 **Babes in Toyland Communications School,** Los Angeles, California. National Instructor - Consultant.

4/84 **1984 West Coast Associated Press Award.** Best PBP-Color for a high school basketball game.

8/80-6/82 **Bobtail College,** Santa Monica, California. Sports Information Director. In charge of sports publicity for Bobtail College.

Hobbies: Head Coach for youth basketball program in Santa Monica since 1986. Enjoy the outdoors. Play golf and racquetball.

PLAY-BY-PLAY SPORTSCAST TRAINING

References: Will be furnished upon request.

THE COMPLETE BROADCAST---AN OVERVIEW.

After reading and practicing Phases 1-4, you should have a very good idea about play-by-play announcing. It is now your responsibility to put all the aspects together for a complete broadcast.

Here is an overview of a play-by-play sportscast:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - OVERVIEW

1. Pre-game show.
2. First half of game - play-by-play.
3. Half-time show.
4. Second half of game - play-by-play.
5. Post-game show and wrap-up.
6. Your preparation and sportsboard.
7. The color commentator.
8. The guests for each show segments.
9. Use of background information.
10. Your knowledge, energy, and play calling.

ILL. # 2

This is just a brief overview of play-by-play, **but how to use this knowledge is important!**

BROADCAST RADIO EQUIPMENT.

If you are broadcasting play-by-play at the present time, you should have a basic knowledge of the equipment that you are using.

If you are not broadcasting play-by-play on radio, but just practicing with a tape recorder, here is a look at some of the equipment you will be working with during the game.

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Although play-by-play radio broadcast equipment may vary, here is a basic set-up of what it includes:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - BASIC RADIO BROADCAST EQUIPMENT

1. **A telephone hook-up (connecting wire)** - games are usually broadcast over phone lines directly to the radio station. Your phone line at the game site has to be ordered through the telephone company at an earlier date.

2. **Two (2) "headsets" and a crowd microphone** - one headset each for the play-by-play announcer and color commentator. This is what you will talk into and hear yourself with.

3. **A tape recorder** - to play taped interviews at the game site.

4. **The "mixer"** - this piece of equipment is the basis for the headsets, crowd microphone, and tape recorder, which all plug into the mixer. This also controls the volume levels of the broadcast. The telephone also plugs into the mixer.

5. **The "amplifier"** - this controls the volume in your headsets enabling you to hear yourself clearly.

ILL. # 3

Again, systems vary, but this is the basic equipment for a radio broadcast.

EQUIPMENT PROBLEMS IN A RADIO BROADCAST.

Never take anything for granted when setting-up your equipment for a broadcast! Always arrive early enough so you can "check" your equipment before the game.

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Here are some things to be aware of when setting-up for a radio broadcast:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - PROBLEMS WITH EQUIPMENT

1. Phone lines - poor or unclear lines (call the phone company).
2. "Mixer" - "patches" in back tend to fail.
3. "Amplifier" - no sound in your headset (check wires).
4. Tape recorder - check recording and playback speeds. Check microphone before you tape an interview.
5. Wires - these stretch,bend, and/or break (have replacements).
6. Radio station - they could have troubles.
7. Headsets - Do they work? Check levels and wiring.

ILL. # 4

THE FUTURE OF PLAY-BY-PLAY SPORTSCASTING.

With expanding cable, network TV and radio stations broadcasting just about every men's and women's high school, junior college, college, and professional sports, **the future of play-by-play is extremely good.**

There are more and more athletic events being broadcast today than ever before.

The need for quality play-by-play announcers is great.

Keep in mind, at most stations, the program director, DJ, or news director usually doubles as the local play-by-play announcer---and is either very inexperienced and/or not very good.

Your abilities to broadcast sporting events will enable you to be more valuable when working at a station, which could lead to a better position.

For the most part, you are in the broadcasting field because you love what you are doing---not for the money! The higher paying jobs will come later, but it does take time.

Developing your play-by-play skills is your first and most important objective when starting out. Gain as much experience and broadcast as many games as possible.

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This is an exciting, fun, stimulating, challenging, and rewarding position---**HAVING A PASSION FOR YOUR PROFESSION---PLAY-BY-PLAY ANNOUNCING!**

You may not begin working at a radio or television station as the play-by-play announcer, but try and become involved in any way possible on the sportscasts.

It could be as the color commentator, engineer, statistician, or hosting the pre-game, half-time, or post-game shows---just be involved. That first job can be the hardest.

Again, the future of sportscasting, play-by-play in particular, is expanding and is very good. The need for play-by-play announcers is great---so stay with it---THE OPPORTUNITY IS THERE TODAY AND IN THE FUTURE!

GENERAL THOUGHTS.....

1. If you need someone to keep statistics, find a person to help. Buy him/her a hotdog and a soft drink. It's worth it!

2. It is alright to have 5-10 seconds of "dead-air" during a broadcast. However, don't let this happen too often during a game.

3. When broadcasting a game, dress properly. A nice shirt and slacks will be fine. Remember you are a professional.

4. If two players become involved in a fight, just describe what is taking place. Maintain your control and don't "go wild."

5. If an injury occurs to a player, again, describe what happened. Try not to guess what the injury is. Wait until you know. Also, be prepared to talk while play is stopped. This happens often.

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6. Line up your pre-game, half-time, and post-game show guests **before the start of the game.**

7. When gathering guests for these shows, **do not announce your guests** until that person is either sitting near you or you can see them. Sometimes the guest is announced and doesn't show up. They can forget or have another committment. **Wait until you are positive the guest is present.**

8. Be prepared, when arriving at a game, for an "unexpected area or a very small space" to set up your equipment. **Courtside seating can get very crowded,** or you may be in a tiny booth high up in the stands, far away from the action.

9. Obtaining background information for a high school game can sometimes be very difficult. Coaches may be unavailable or hard to reach. One alternative is to call the local papers and writers who cover those teams. If necessary, contact an athletic director or vice-principal.

10. There are "roadblocks" to obtaining background information, **but plan ahead and be prepared when readying yourself for a season.** Gather as much information on teams as early as possible (rosters, schedules, stats, background, etc.).

THE AUDITION TAPE "PACKAGE."

First of all, there is no **ONE WAY** to prepare an audition tape, but there are general guidelines that you should follow:

1. The audition tape should be a neat "package."
2. It should be labeled with your name, address and telephone number on it. It should either be typed or neatly printed.

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3. Briefly identify what is on the tape, ie.: play-by-play and interview.
4. SLATE your tape. As we indicated in the course introduction, slating your tape means to include a brief self introduction on tape: Your name, address, telephone number and what to expect:

PBP-ST ILLUSTRATION - INTRODUCTION

"On this tape will be 3 minutes of basketball play-by-play between Team A and Team B. That will be followed by a 3 minute interview with Team A coach Fuzzy Jones."

ILL. # 5

5. The tape should not have any other "extraneous" material still on it. Be sure to "bulk" (erase) the tape before you actually put the play-by-play and/or interview material on it. Don't leave "practice" material on the tape. You might sound great in the segments you want the station manager to hear, but the "practice" material might turn your potential employer off to the idea of hiring you.

6. The audio tape should be accompanied by a "resume'" or, as professional recruiters would say, a "background sheet." We cannot emphasize too much that this should be neatly typed or printed. **DO NOT WRITE IT OUT.** If you can't type, hire someone who can. Go with your broadcast experience first.

7. The audio tape and "background material" should be part of the "package" that includes THE COVER LETTER.

    a. The COVER LETTER can help make or break your chances of being heard by any potential employer. It should be neatly typed, no strikeovers, no smudges.

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b. COVER LETTERS will vary in content depending on your own background and the job you are seeking. But, it should be "target" specific. Don't send it to "To Whom It May Concern." Be very specific. Send it to:

Mr./Ms./Dr., etc., Joseph Jones (if that's the station manager's name). Or send it to the program director, or owner, etc. But know the name of the person, the title, the correct spelling, the name of the station, the correct address.

8. Nothing turns off a potential employer faster than opening a letter to someone who is no longer there, or where the job title is wrong, or it is misspelled. Check these things out BEFORE you send the "package" of audition tape, cover letter and resume.

9. THE COVER LETTER needs to be **specific about the job(s) you have in mind.** If it's basketball play-by-play and sports reporting, then target that area. If it's football, basketball and baseball play-by-play plus an interview show, be specific there---as much as you can.

10. How do you know the station's format?

There are various ways to check this out. There are media lists in BROADCAST YEARBOOK which will give you the name and address of every radio and television station in the country. It will break the stations down by what type of programming they do and who the top management people are at the station. If in doubt, make a telephone call to the station to be sure.

11. THE COVER LETTER should be no longer than one page. Keep it to the point and simple. Don't let your ego take over in the cover letter, but do express confidence in your ability to do the job well, to get along with other people and how much you can help them in their programming goals.

Don't ask what the station can do for you, ask what you can do for the station, (to paraphrase the late John F. Kennedy).

When you finally mail your package, if you want your tape back, send along a self-addressed stamped envelope. Otherwise, you probably won't see it again.

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COVER LETTER : SAMPLE.

To: Mr.. John Paul Jones
Station Manager
XXXX Radio
Duluth, Minn., 11111

Dear Mr.. Jones:

This is in response to your advertisement in _____ regarding a basketball announcing position with your station.

I would be very interested in handling play-by-play for XXXX and its network stations for the Duluth Panthers basketball team.

My background includes two seasons as play-by-play announcer for the Denver Ducks professional football team, one season as host for Denver Duck pre-game and post-game shows and one year as sports anchor for Radio Station RRRR in Colorado Springs. I have spent the last two seasons doing play-by-play for the Colorado Springs Seagulls basketball team.

Enclosed is an air check of Denver Duck football, Colorado Springs basketball and a short interview with Colorado Springs Seagull basketball coach Irving Dunk.

I believe you will find my play-by-play to be professional in every respect with considerable energy, enthusiasm and the ability to accurately describe the action on the court.

It has always been my desire to move to the upper Midwest area and I would welcome the opportunity to meet with you about the Duluth Panther play-by-play position.

I look forward to visiting with you in the near future if you believe my background, abilities and professionalism meet the qualifications you seek.

Sincerely,

William Wannabe
7777 Broadcast Circle
Aero Gulch, Colorado 33333
(telephone)

AUDITION TAPE .

We Have discussed this already, but it is certainly worth going over. The audition tape should include your absolute best segment of play-by-play---whether it be football, basketball, baseball, hockey, ping pong, whatever. It should be the sport(s) the station is covering. It wouldn't do much good, probably, to send a tape of the local frisbee contest if the station doesn't cover frisbee competition!

Once you have completed the audition tape, keep the "MASTER" copy. You may want to use this again for other stations.

MORE GENERAL THOUGHTS.....

NETWORKING:

If fate smiles upon you and you get that first job, the next project you have is to "network." That is to make contact with people, to project a warm, professional image and the desire to work hard. These contacts may not pay off immediately, but over a period of time "networking" will pay large dividends. Maintain those contacts. When you meet someone a second time go ahead and reintroduce yourself. Ask about them, how they are doing, what their next projects are.

DON'T keep pestering them for a job. But, do let them know that you would be interested in taking on new and different challenges.

Two key elements to success in this business are:

1. **PERSEVERANCE**
2. **EGO**

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Perseverance:

You are going to be rejected. Probably many times. As mentioned earlier, there are a thousand reasons why you might be rejected and a thousand why you might get the job. Personalities have a lot to do with it. Luck, being in the right place, knowing the right person, etc., all come into play.

Conduct yourself like a professional and the payoff will eventually be there---IF YOU PERSEVERE. **Do not take rejection personally.** Many talented people, more talented than some who get hired, don't get the job. Maybe it's the color of their hair, how tall they are, where they come from, multitudes of reasons.

Ego:

Ego is something we all have. It allows us to function, to move on with confidence, to overcome rejection. You must have a strong ego to move forward in life and in broadcasting specifically. This is a highly subjective business. If they like you...they like you. If they don't hire you, maybe they still like you, but have hired someone else.

Do not confuse EGO with being an egotist or egotistical. This can create problems for you. If you are an egotist, you may not have the talent to back it up. You will find that workers will eventually resent you and can make life difficult for you---unless, of course, you become a super star and they have to fall at your feet. That is rare, so don't let your ego get in the way of getting along with others, working with the station staff, other reporters, preparing, asking questions.

Be knowledgeable but don't sound like a "know it all." **Work hard and you will eventually see the payoff.**

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YOUR FINAL ASSIGNMENT: Phase Five.

Again, try to do a live game and find the best consecutive three minutes of play-by-play action (unedited and with no tape stops).

Have your audio tape and sportsboard available for critique.

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ADDENDUM

PLAY-BY-PLAY SPORTSCAST TRAINING FOR THE ULTRA ADVANCED BROADCASTER

BY: LOU RIGGS

TRACKING THE GAME.

This is a term I use in keeping up with the action so I can refer back to it during the game. Don't try this until you become comfortable with terminology, pacing and ability to keep up with the action.

By "Tracking The Game," I **mean to keep a running play-by-play on paper.** As you progress up the ladder, you may have people doing this for you. Until then, you will need to be able to find a way of following the action so you can go back and recap it during a time-out; use it in your broadcast, or post-game wrap-up.

FOOTBALL.

Enclosed is a sample sheet of something I have used while doing a football game. It allows you to show down and yards to go, yards gained on previous play, whether it was a run, incomplete pass, punt, etc. You can modify this, but it will allow you the opportunity to go back and highlight where the drive started, the key plays, who made them, etc.

BASKETBALL.

Enclosed is a sample sheet which has allowed me to keep up with the scoring, who did it, time of game, and to see trends and patterns. It's enormously helpful in determining a game theme or trend, or big moment. **Again, this will be something to think about sometime DOWN THE ROAD.**

BASEBALL.

Your scorebook and index cards will take care of things very nicely.

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.BASKETBALL NOTES.

TEAM A SCORING	A	B	TEAM B SCORING	1st QUARTER
22 Jump	2			
		2	13 Hook	
		4	13 Tip-in	Steal by 12
21 Lay-in	4			
		7	22 3 pt.	7:02
				13 -10 pts. 4/4 FG
				2/2 FT
	14	16		
				2nd QUARTER

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GAME FORMAT SHEET.

On the next page, you will find what I call a "Game Format Sheet." This would vary, depending on the sport, or the level of competition, For example, a high school basketball game has four quarters of play, so does professional basketball. But, college basketball consists of two halves of play, so this SAMPLE SHEET could be modified to show ("First Half" and "Second Half").

These sample sheets will give you several important reminders:

1. Who the teams are.
2. Where the game is being played.
3. Who the officials are.
4. Quarter scores and cumulative score.
5. Identifies your half-time guest.
6. Note space to include upcoming games, results, other games tonight, injuries, story lines, key stats, league standings, etc.
7. Formats to follow on "outcues," back to the station for commercials, your next broadcast, and a format you might use to wrap up the broadcast.

Obviously, you can modify these depending on the sport involved.

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GAME FORMAT SHEET

You're listening to the high school game of the week on XXXX Radio....

Score by Quarters	1	2	3	4	Final
TEAM A	13	12 (25)	13 (38)	13 (51)	51
TEAM B	12	12 (24)	12 (36)	16 (52)	52

Records:

Officials: Referee: Umpire:

Halftime Guest:

Notes

We'll be back for our final wrap-up from (TEAM B HIGH SCHOOL) right after this message...you're listening to the high school game of the week on XXXX...

Next Broadcast: _____

That wraps it up from _____ where _____ has beaten ____ _____ (SCORE) _____. We hope you've enjoyed the broadcast and wish you a very good _____. Executive producer for the XXXX High School game of the week is John Paul Jones- - -In-studio engineer _____. For (COLOR COMMENTATOR) this is (YOUR NAME) , thanks for listening and good night.

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